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Many police personnel favour broader coercive powers, says 2025 survey

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Kushare and Ajaya win silver medals

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INSIDE



Meta apologises for its removal of PM Modi's video

NEW DELHI

Facebook's parent company Meta is said to have apologised after Prime Minister Narendra Modi's video was briefly taken down by Facebook owing to what an automated platform alert initially described as a "legal request". » PAGE 4

13 Indian crewmen trapped in Ukrainian port

CHENNAI

Fifteen sailors, including 13 Indians, are trapped in a "terrible and life-threatening situation" at the Ukrainian port of Chornomorsk in the Black Sea owing to missile and drone attacks in the vicinity, says Forward Seamen's Union of India (FSUI). » PAGE 6

Zelenskyy hails talks with Trump on Patriot system

WASHINGTON

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy hailed a "good meeting" with U.S. counterpart Donald Trump at the White House on Tuesday, saying they discussed licences to produce Patriot air-defence interceptors and ways to revive talks with Russia. » PAGE 14

Multiple strains of dengue raise risk of disease

NEW DELHI

India may be entering a more perilous phase in its dengue epidemic, with multiple strains of the virus now circulating simultaneously across much of the country, raising concerns over an increased risk of severe disease, according to a two-year study. » PAGE 6

Release minors held during students' stir: SC

The top court is considering an independent investigation into charges of excesses by police

States allowed to proceed with probes, police are restrained from 'coercive action' against students

CJP spokesperson Saurav Das says on X that the order is in 'direct contradiction' to govt.'s pledge

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Tuesday indicated that it would consider constituting a high-powered investigation team to conduct a "thorough, fair, and independent" inquiry into allegations of police excesses during the recent student protests in Delhi and several States.

While permitting the State authorities to proceed with the investigation of the FIRs registered in relation to the protests, the court ordered the immediate release of all minors arrested in connection with the demonstrations and restrained the police from taking coercive action against "protesting students" unless they had criminal antecedents.

The interim order permitting the authorities to proceed with the investigation of the existing FIRs raised concerns among the protesters on Tuesday. Saurav Das, the CJP's spokesperson, said in a post on X that the order "raises extremely serious concerns" and is in "direct contradiction" to the Centre's assurance to the "youth of this nation".

Underlining that the Constitution guarantees the right to peaceful protest, a Bench headed by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant, while hearing a batch of petitions alleging disproportionate force by the police during the protests, observed that an independent probe was necessary to examine the allegations of police violence through a "scientific" and "evidence-based" inquiry.

"Whosoever has committed excess, committed atrocities on innocent people, the law will take care of them. For that, there needs to be a completely independent and fair investigation... Probe is meaningless if no responsibility is fixed," CJI Kant said.

The Bench, also comprising Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V. Mohana, issued notices to the Union government, the Delhi government and the Chief Secretaries of Maharashtra, Bihar, Assam, Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, West Bengal and Kerala, directing them to place their responses on record.

Whosoever has committed excess, committed atrocities on innocent people, the law will take care of them. For that, there needs to be a completely independent and fair investigation... Probe is meaningless if no responsibility is fixed



SURYA KANT
Chief Justice of India

The interim directions came while the top court was hearing a batch of petitions alleging the use of disproportionate force by the police against protesters during demonstrations over the NEET examination paper leak, including the July 20 Parliament march in Delhi and subsequent protests in several States.

The Delhi government and the Chief Secretaries of Maharashtra, Bihar, Assam, Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, West Bengal and Kerala, directing them to place their responses on record.

The interim directions came while the top court was hearing a batch of petitions alleging the use of disproportionate force by the police against protesters during demonstrations over the NEET examination paper leak, including the July 20 Parliament march in Delhi and subsequent protests in several States.

Police authorised pellet gun use on July 20: records

NEW DELHI

A general diary entry filed at a police station in New Delhi has revealed that the Rapid Action Force fired two rounds from an anti-riot gun on the directions of a Deputy Commissioner of Police rank officer. » PAGE 4

the demonstrations. While permitting the police to continue investigating the FIRs registered in relation to the protests, it restrained the authorities from taking any coercive action against students unless they had criminal antecedents.

As an interim measure, the Bench directed the police authorities to preserve all CCTV footage, drone recordings, body-worn camera footage, wireless communication records and PCR call records relating to the protests. It also ordered that while the police may preserve the digital

data of protesters for the purposes of the investigation, they shall not disclose any personal information in the public domain.

Senior advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan, appearing for petitioner Shailendra Mani Tripathi, referred to videographic evidence allegedly showing the use of pellet guns and electric batons against protesters and urged the court to fix accountability. He also questioned the absence of any prohibitory orders in the Jantar Mantar area, the lack of name tags on police personnel and the deployment of officers in plain clothes for crowd-control duties.

"There are reports of electric shock weapons being used on protesters. The RAF has admitted the use of projectile-action guns (PAGs) against unarmed protesters. We have set out the details and placed credible media reports on record," senior advocate Shyam Divan submitted.

Acknowledging the concerns raised by the petitioners, the Chief Justice observed that an independent probe would look into the allegations.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Delhi Police and the Union government, submitted that he had no objection to the constitution of an independent probe. He also brought to the Bench's notice that several police personnel had allegedly been injured by miscreants during the protests.

"If students have suffered in any manner, perpetrators have to be brought to book," he said, adding that "anti-social elements" may have infiltrated the demonstrations.

The Bench observed that both "narratives" warranted a fair examination, cautioning that there was always a "danger" of a peaceful movement being discredited.

The Bench posted the matter for further hearing on August 3.

EDITORIAL
» PAGE 8

Back to the sea



Rosy prospects: Fishermen mend and arrange their nets at Kalamukku harbour in Vypin, Ernakulam, as they prepare to venture into the sea after the annual trawling ban in Kerala ends at midnight on July 31. R.K.NITHIN

'Gen Alpha' students stage walkout for basic facilities

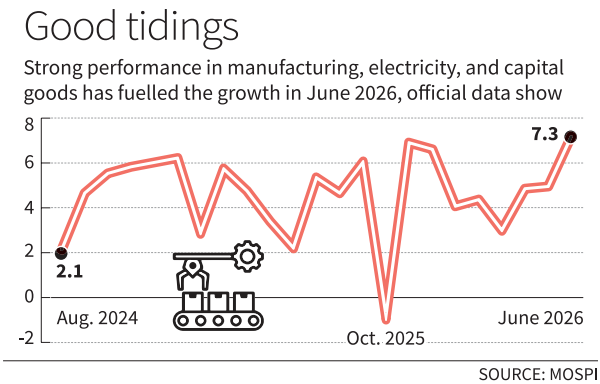
Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

Days after the Cockroach Janta Party-led student protest in Delhi drew national attention, a similar expression of dissent has emerged from Uttar Pradesh's Fatehpur district on Tuesday.

Hundreds of students at a government-aided school walked out of their classrooms and staged a protest demanding better infrastructure. The school administration had to call in police personnel to maintain order.

FULL STORY ON » PAGE 2

Industrial growth hits 23-month high of 7.3%



T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

India's industrial growth hit a near two-year peak of 7.3% in June 2026, fuelled by strong performance in manufacturing, electricity, and capital goods, official data released on Tuesday showed.

Analysts, however, caution that this strong performance might not continue in the face of a lower-than-expected monsoon, and continued uncertainty due to the war in West Asia.

The data on the Index of Industrial Production (IIP), released by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation, showed that the index's growth in June was the fastest since July 2024, a 23-month high. The index had grown 5.1% in May 2026.

Within the index, the manufacturing sector grew at a 23-month high of 7.8% in June 2026, compared with 5.5% in May, and 2.4% in June of last year.

"The sharp uptick reflects broad-based strength in industrial activity, supported by improving manufacturing output, resilient domestic demand, and sustained momentum in investment-led sectors,"

Dim outlook ahead

The capital goods sector also saw growth accelerating to 14.2% in June 2026, up from 3.45% in June last year. However, analysts say that despite this growth, the outlook for the months ahead is not as positive.

"While this reflects steady capital expenditure execution, our forward-looking credit outlook adopts a cautious stance," Vikrant Chaturvedi, Associate Director at Brickwork Ratings said. "The 9.3% growth in intermediate goods supports near-term supply chain stability, yet the broader macroeconomic landscape is clouded by significant risks."

The prospect of a below-normal monsoon threatens rural consumption and poses upward inflation pressure while regional tensions in West Asia continue to drive oil price volatility, according to him.

Many people feared trapped in mall after Japan quake

Agence France-Presse
TOKYO

"Many people" were feared trapped in a stricken shopping mall in Japan late on Tuesday, authorities said, after a major earthquake toppled buildings, sparked fires and reportedly injured more than 100.

Private broadcaster *TBS* reported that a "considerable number" were feared dead inside the mall in the town of Kashima after the fire brigade said that the second floor collapsed in the 7.1-magnitude tremor.

Public broadcaster *NHK* cited police sources as saying that between 20 and 30 employees could not be contacted, showing foot-



Rescue workers conducting a search and rescue operation at a shopping centre in Kashima Town, Japan on Tuesday. REUTERS

age of emergency vehicles with flashing red lights outside.

The police said they could not confirm any fatalities inside the building. *Kyodo News* reported that four persons had been taken to hospital, all of them conscious. Multiple people were also believed to be unaccounted for at a Japan Paper Industries factory where the tip of a chimney fell down, *NHK* reported, citing sources.

ken to hospital, all of them conscious. Multiple people were also believed to be unaccounted for at a Japan Paper Industries factory where the tip of a chimney fell down, *NHK* reported, citing sources.

One person was killed when a house collapsed during the quake, *Kyodo* reported.

Widespread damage

Footage elsewhere in the southwestern Kumamoto region on the island of Kyushu aired by *NHK* earlier showed several blazes, damaged bridges, a derailed cargo train and a number of houses threatening to topple over.

The tremor had a magnitude of 7.1, the Japan Meteorological Agency (JMA) said, but reached the highest level of seven on Japan's Shindo scale of shaking. A succession of aftershocks followed, including one with a magnitude of 6.1.

Many roads were closed and high-speed shinkansen train services were suspended in the region. Kumamoto airport was closed before being re-opened on Tuesday evening.

"We are still assessing the extent of injuries and property damage, but I have been informed that there have already been several injuries," Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi said.

"Power outages and fires are happening in some areas, and roads and bridges have been damaged and buildings collapsed," she said.

The Japanese military has mobilised 3,600 personnel for disaster relief operations and sent 20 aircraft to assess the damage

from the air, the Defence Minister said.

The JMA initially issued an alert for a possible tsunami of up to one metre, but withdrew the warning at around 6:10 pm.

Unverified footage shared on social media showed parts of a wall at the centuries-old Kumamoto Castle collapsing.

About 45,000 households and facilities had no power in the Kumamoto region, according to local utility Kyushu Electric Power.

Japan is one of the world's most seismically active countries, sitting on top of four major tectonic plates along the western edge of the Pacific "Ring of Fire".

INBRIEF



Sharad Pawar again dismisses speculation on NCP merger

NCP (SP) chief Sharad Pawar on Tuesday once again dismissed speculation over a possible merger of the two factions of the Nationalist Congress Party. Responding to question about the buzz about the two NCP factions coming together, Mr. Pawar said, “It has no relevance.” NCP (SP) leaders had claimed earlier that then NCP chief and Maharashtra Deputy CM Ajit Pawar, who died in an air crash in January, was firm on merging both the factions. PTI

No paper leak in Punjab, Opposition lying: Minister

Punjab Finance Minister Harpal Singh Cheema on Tuesday rejected the Opposition’s charge of a paper leak in the State, claiming that it is trying to spread lies against the AAP government. Addressing the media here, Mr. Cheema said there has been no paper leak in the past four years of the Bhagwant Mann government. Opposition parties have been attacking the Mann government over the issue of a cheating racket detected recently in a pharmacy officer recruitment exam and are demanding the resignation of Education Minister Harjot Singh Bains and Health Minister Balbir Singh. PTI

Kolkata Police drop suo motu FIR against protesters for violence

A city court grants bail to all 16 accused who were in custody after FIR was withdrawn; cases of assault on journalists during protest to continue

Seniuti Sengupta
KOLKATA

Kolkata Police on Tuesday withdrew an FIR which it had filed suo motu against protesters for allegedly resorting to violence during a procession on July 24 in the city’s Esplanade area in support of students protesting at Jantar Mantar in Delhi demanding the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan as Union Education Minister.

After police dropped the charges, the Chief Metropolitan Magistrate’s court on Tuesday granted bail to all 16 accused on a bond of ₹500. Kolkata Police had arrested the accused from different places in and around the city and they were originally scheduled to remain in judicial custody till July 30.

‘Protection not for all’
The West Bengal Home and Hill Affairs Department later issued the formal order withdrawing the case. It clarified that no coercive measures shall be



Accused in the student protest violence case being produced before the Bankshall Court in Kolkata on Tuesday. ANI

taken against the students who participated in the protests. However, it also said, “The above protection shall not extend to persons having criminal antecedents, as mandated in the order of the Hon’ble Court...”

The development came a day after the Cockroach Janta Party said the Union government should not breach the agreement to withdraw all police cases against protesters. Similar FIRs registered against protesters in Assam and Bihar were withdrawn on Monday.

A total of 16 people had

been arrested for their alleged role in the violence by Kolkata Police. Seven FIRs were registered in connection with the violence, which included a suo motu FIR by the police and six other FIRs registered on the basis of complaints made by journalists who were assaulted by a mob.

Chief Minister Suvenhu Adhikari had earlier claimed that the accused will be booked under the newly passed West Bengal Public Safety and Control of Anti-Social Activities Act, 2026, also commonly called the ‘Goonda Act’.

‘A lawyer in court dress, agents delivering food’: people who landed in Assam Police’s custody

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

On the afternoon of July 24, advocate Ariful Islam, 28, was standing near the site of a NEET paper leak protest in Guwahati when policemen stopped by and took him into custody. They later registered his arrest at 9 p.m. on that day.

“What is most alarming is that, at the time of his detention, he (Mr. Islam) was in the court dress of an advocate and repeatedly identified himself as a member of the Bar, producing his Bar Council identity card before the police personnel present at the spot,” read a statement issued by the Assam unit of the All India Lawyers Association for Justice.

The arrested advocate, it added, was merely a bystander at the protest venue in Guwahati.

On the same day, 23-year-old Mustahid Ahmed was also arrested after he reportedly asked a policeman outside the protest venue why his name tag was missing from his uniform.

Mr. Islam and Mr. Ahmed were two of five persons held in Guwahati on that day. The other three were Chinmoy Deka, a 24-year-old student, and



Security personnel detaining a demonstrator protesting against the NEET paper leak in Guwahati on July 25. ANI

food delivery agents Amir Ali, 26, and Mehdi Alam, 26. A member of the lawyers’ association said the two food delivery agents had nothing to do with the protest.

The Assam government has now withdrawn five cases leading to the arrest of 13 people who participated in the protests against the NEET examination paper leak, announcing that the “matter shall be treated as closed”.

In an order issued late Monday night, the police said no adverse action would be taken against the protesters. It also said the process to review the arrest of the 13 people picked up on July 23 and 24 was being expedited.

The Guwahati arrests came a day after a Students’ Federation of India

(SFI) protest on July 23 in solidarity with activist Sonam Wangchuk and agitating students nationwide seeking education reforms.

Among the others, three students were arrested in Lakhimpur, while Congress leader Birinchi Bora was held in Nagaon town.

Most of them were booked under penal sections dealing with criminal conspiracy; endangering the sovereignty, unity and integrity of India; endangering human life or personal safety; using criminal force to stop a public servant from doing his or her job; wrongful confinement; rioting and unlawful assembly; and publishing or circulating false statements.

The government’s latest decision followed the release of more than 50 people detained on July 25.

Echoes of Jantar Mantar in U.P. as ‘Gen Alpha’ school students stage protest for basic facilities

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

Days after the Cockroach Janta Party-led student protest in Delhi drew national attention, a similar expression of dissent emerged from Uttar Pradesh’s Fatehpur district on Tuesday, when hundreds of students at a government-aided school walked out of their classrooms and staged a protest demanding better infrastructure.

The school administration called police personnel to maintain order.

Videos from the protest, which gained wider attention after being shared by Chandrashekhar Azad, Nagina MP and president of the Azad Samaj Party (Kanshi Ram), and Aam Aadmi Party, show police asking students to clear the road, even as the demonstrators continue marching.



Students said midday meals had never been served as per rules. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The demonstration took place at Sarvodaya Inter College, a government-aided school with nearly 1,800 students, in Kishanpur town. Students marched through the locality holding portraits of B.R. Ambedkar and carrying placards that read: ‘College ki vyavastha sudharo, bachchon ka bhavishya sanwaro’ (Improve the college’s condition, secure the future of its students)’.

Abhishek Sonkar, a student, alleged that midday meals had never been served in accordance with the prescribed menu.

In his post, the Nagina MP alleged that repeated representations to the school administration had failed to bring about any meaningful change. He concluded the post with the slogan, ‘Jai Bhim! Jai Gen Alpha!’

‘Attended Delhi protest’
Principal of the school, L.B. Singh, told *The Hindu* that several demands, including the installation of four fans in each classroom, a water cooler and the provision of meals as per the prescribed menu, had been addressed immediately. He added that a few students from the higher grades were learnt to have participated in the protest at Jantar Mantar.

Students involved in NEET paper leak agitation facing police crackdown, says AISA

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The All India Students’ Association (AISA) on Tuesday alleged that protesters involved in the agitation against the NEET paper leak are facing a police crackdown across the country.

The students’ body claimed that multiple SFI activists, including former JNUSU president Dhananjay, AISA Bihar secretary Dipankar Mishra, and Patna University activists Divyam Kumar and Saba Aftreen, have been arrested in Bihar.

AISA national president Neha, one of the prominent faces during the protest, said during a press conference at the Press Club of India: “We were assured that students protesting peacefully would not face



AISA national president Neha and DU unit secretary Anjali addressing the media in New Delhi on Tuesday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

repression. However, what we have witnessed is continued arrests, arbitrary detentions and intimidation of students across the country. The government must uphold its promises, release those detained and engage with the concerns of students.”

In addition to arrests made in Bihar, West Bengal and Jharkhand, AISA said that protesters were sent notices in Delhi’s Jamia Na-

gar. “It has come to our notice that in Jamia Nagar, student peotesters are being sent notices based on retina and face scanning for their presence at Jantar Mantar. AISA Jamia has issued a helpline for legal aid in the matter,” AISA said in a statement.

The organisation reiterated its demand to release all protesters and give compensation for those injured in police brutality.

Withdraw all cases against students: Pinarayi to Kerala CM

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Leader of the Opposition in Kerala Assembly Pinarayi Vijayan has written to Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan demanding an unconditional withdrawal of all cases filed in the State against those who took to the streets to express solidarity with the Jantar Mantar students’ agitation.

The office of the Chief Minister on Tuesday informed that Mr. Vijayan’s letter has been forwarded to the Home Department for further action.

In his letter, Mr. Vijayan said that

while the Chief Minister himself was seen joining the protests at Jantar Mantar, alongside the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi, it is inappropriate that the very government he leads in

Reports indicate that the police have booked cases against nearly 5,000 people for staging protests

Kerala has charge-sheeted many who agitated in Kerala to support the students.

He also pointed out that there are complaints that false cases were being foisted against many who took part in peaceful protests.

Reports indicate that the Kerala police have booked cases against nearly 5,000 people across various parts of the State for participating in these protests. As the Centre has agreed to withdraw all cases against students, the United Democratic Front government should not delay in withdrawing the cases filed by the Kerala police, Mr. Vijayan said.

BJP bids to stave off JSP, RJD challenge as campaigning ends for Bankipur byelection

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

Campaigning for the July 30 Bankipur Assembly byelection in Bihar came to a close on Tuesday, with candidates making a final push to secure the seat vacated by BJP national president Nitin Nabin following his election to the Rajya Sabha in April.

The BJP is making an all-out effort to retain the seat and has fielded 32-year-old youth wing leader Neeraj Kumar Sinha as its candidate. The bypoll will mark the electoral debut of Prashant Kishor, the 49-year-old founder of the Jan Suraa Party (JSP), which failed to win any seat in the Assembly poll last year.

The Opposition Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) has nominated Rekha Kumari,



JSP candidate Prashant Kishor addressing a rally and BJP’s Neeraj Kumar Sinha meeting voters in Bankipur on Tuesday. AMIT BHELARI

who was the runner-up from the seat in the Assembly poll that was won by Mr. Nabin by a margin of over 50,000 votes. RJD working president Tejashwi Yadav joined the party’s campaign only on July 27.

Although 25 candidates are in the fray, the contest appears to be primarily between the BJP and the



JSP. The Bankipur constituency has nearly four lakh voters. The Kayasth and Yadav communities together account for about 25% of the electorate. Muslims and Chandravanshis also have sizeable numbers, with both communities constituting nearly 20% of the voters. The Vaishya, Dalit, Bhumihar, Rajput,

Brahmin, Kurmi, and Kushwaha communities each make up between 3% and 8% of the electorate.

Key concerns

On the BJP candidate’s roadshow, Sanjay Gupta, a trader from Meethapur, said, “We are not looking at caste; for us, the candidate is more important.”

Voters also expressed concern over issues such as the NEET paper leak row and alleged theft of donations at Ram Temple.

Mr. Kishor addressed public meetings in Peermuhani, Sabzibagh, and Jai Prakash Nagar. Speaking to the gathering at Peermuhani, the JSP leader said, “When you go to cast the vote, think about the future of your children.”

The results will be declared on August 3.

Seat vacated due to Cong. MLA conviction, high-stakes battle in the offing in Datia byelection

Press Trust of India
DATIA (M.P.)

Campaigning for the July 30 Datia Assembly bypoll in Madhya Pradesh, which will witness a direct contest between traditional rivals - the ruling BJP and Opposition Congress - came to a close on Tuesday evening.

The BJP has fielded Ashutosh Tiwari, whose candidature caused heartburn among the supporters of former State Home Minister Narottam Mishra, while the Congress has nominated Ghanashyam Singh. Damodar Singh Yadav of the Aazad Samaj Party is also in the fray, making the fight triangular.

The bypoll was necessitated after Congress MLA



Union Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan during a rally in support of BJP candidate Ashutosh Tiwari for Datia Assembly bypoll. FILE PHOTO

Rajendra Bharti lost his Assembly membership following his conviction in a cheating case. Votes will be counted on August 3.

The State Election Commission issued a statement saying all preparations, including the security arrangements, have been com-

pleted to conduct the polls in a free and fair manner.

The ruling BJP has made development its main poll plank, while the Congress is countering it with claims of crop losses and anger among OBCs over the purported denial of full 27% reservation.

Gujarat’s Manjalpur to go to bypoll tomorrow

Press Trust of India
AHMEDABAD

Campaigning for the byelection to the Manjalpur Assembly seat in Gujarat’s Vadodara district ended on Tuesday evening, with polling scheduled on July 30 to decide the fate of two candidates in the fray.

The bypoll was necessitated by the death of senior BJP MLA Yogesh Patel on June 2. The ruling BJP has fielded former Vadodara Municipal Corporation councillor Satish Govindbhai Patel, while the Congress has nominated its Gujarat vice president Bhikhabhai Rabari.

Counting of votes will take place on August 3, said office of the Gujarat Chief Electoral Officer.

Mekedatu
row: Vijay
urges Modi
to intervene

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Tuesday wrote to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, seeking his intervention to ensure no statutory or administrative approval is granted to the proposed Mekedatu project unless it is demonstrably consistent with the Cauvery Water Disputes Tribunal's award and the judgment of the Supreme Court.

He also called for the withdrawal of the reply given by Union Minister of State for Jal Shakti Raj Bhushan Choudhary in the Rajya Sabha on July 27 with regard to the project.

The Minister had said the Supreme Court's judgment of February 16, 2018, did not stipulate that Karnataka should obtain the consent of the lower riparian States before constructing a structure across the Cauvery. Mr. Vijay said the Minister had made the reply without referring to the settled law and legal principles in inter-State water issues. "This disappointing reply from the Union Minister of State for Jal Shakti seems to have been made without taking into consideration the prevailing legal position and settled law with regard to the consent of the lower riparian States," he said.

The Chief Minister also said the Supreme Court had, in the Alamatti case between Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh, ruled that the consent of the lower riparian State was absolutely necessary.



Taking stock: Pinarayi Vijayan, who was then the Chief Minister, at an LDF election rally in March. FILE PHOTO

Campaign centred
on Pinarayi cost LDF
in Kerala poll: CPI(M)

G Anand
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Central Committee of the Communist Party of India (Marxist)'s review of the Assembly election results pointed out that "personalising the electoral campaign and centring it solely around" former Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan were among the several factors that cost the Left Democratic Front (LDF) its "political initiative" in the polls.

The review, published online on Monday, noted that individualising the campaign enfeebled the party's core Left-secular messaging against the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF)'s "reactionary ruling class" bias and rendered Mr. Vijayan the prime target of a vilification campaign.

The assessment noted that the CPI(M)'s disproportionate stress on the social capital generated by the previous LDF government's development and welfare policies obfuscated the party's anti-corporate,

anti-communal, and anti-neoliberal messaging to the masses.

Political vacuum

The consequent dearth of a distinctly Left-secular message created a political vacuum that the Congress, Indian Union Muslim League, and the Jamaat-e-Islami sought to fill by pushing the patently false narrative that the CPI(M) was in cahoots with the Hindu majoritarian forces backing the Bharatiya Janata Party.

The distorted campaign "influenced and misled some sections of the Christian minority into joining the reactionary gang-up against the LDF".

The Central Committee noted that Communist Party of India's stance on PM SHRI gave a leg-up to the UDF's propaganda campaign that an "undercurrent exists" between the CPI(M) and the BJP.

The review warned against heedlessness on the part of leaders when addressing the media or the public.

Release Cauvery water to
T.N., panel tells Karnataka

Committee orders State to release 3,500 cusecs of water daily for 15 days from today; Karnataka likely to appeal against order; Minister says present storage can only meet drinking water needs

B.S. Satish Kumar
BENGALURU

The Cauvery Water Regulation Committee (CWRC), which met in Delhi on Tuesday to review the situation in the drought-hit Cauvery basin, has directed Karnataka to release 4 tmcft of water to Tamil Nadu at a rate of 3,500 cusecs a day for 15 days.

After examining the live storage in Karnataka and Tamil Nadu reservoirs and the anticipated worsening of El Nino conditions, the committee directed Karnataka to ensure a flow of 3,500 cusecs at the Biligundlu measuring gauge on the inter-State boundary, commencing from 8 a.m.



Interim relief: Tamil Nadu had received only 3.543 tmcft of water as against the prescribed 35.391 tmcft till July 26. K. MURALI KUMAR

on Wednesday. When contacted by *The Hindu*, Karnataka Water Resources Minister K. Ramalinga Reddy said the State would examine the possibility of filing an appeal against the order before the Cauvery

Water Management Authority (CWMA), which is the apex body that monitors implementation of Cauvery water release.

Mr. Reddy said he would hold a meeting with officials concerned in this re-

gard on Wednesday in Bengaluru and later consult Chief Minister D. K. Shiva-kumar to arrive at a decision. He maintained that the storage in the four reservoirs of Cauvery basin in Karnataka was sufficient to take care of only the drinking water requirements of the State.

Till July 26, Tamil Nadu had received only 3.543 tmcft of water as against the prescribed 35.391 tmcft, which accounted for only 10.01% of the stipulated quantum, the State said.

Tamil Nadu contended that it had not received its pro-rata share in accordance with the inflows into Karnataka's reservoirs and there was a backlog of 9.46 tmcft.

RSS distances itself from Kerala Hindutva
ideologue's remarks on student protests

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

The Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh has condemned the controversial remarks made by Hindutva ideologue T.G. Mohandas against the student protests at Jantar Mantar.

In a video posted on his YouTube channel, Mr. Mohandas had said that he "would have shot" the protesters if he were in

control. A former head of the BJP's Kerala intellectual cell, he said in another video that secular women who take part in protests "enjoy being gangraped."

'Not an RSS official'

K.B. Sreekumar, Saha Prantha Karyavah (South Kerala) of the RSS, said in a statement that Mr. Mohandas's comments on the protests were "his personal thoughts and he is not

an RSS official at any level".

He said the RSS did not agree with his views and "such views should be condemned in every highest possible manner".

Following complaints from several parties, Kerala Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala had ordered a police investigation into the controversial remarks.

Opposition leader Pinarayi Vijayan had demand-

ed that the government register a case against Mr. Mohandas, while pointing out that his statements "reflected the Sangh Parivar's desire to curb dissent".

After his statements invited widespread protests, Mr. Mohandas clarified that his remarks were intended to be "satirical" and "hypothetical". He alleged that short clips of his comments were taken out of context.

INBRIEF



Kumbh fame actor should
not be taken out of Kerala: HC

The Kerala High Court has ordered that the woman actor who had gone viral during the Kumbh Mela should not be taken out of Ernakulam without the court's or her consent. It was reviewing an order issued by the National Commission for Scheduled Tribes to the State Police Chief for her production before the Madhya Pradesh Police to facilitate her reunion with her parents. The court noted that the commission's order was on a plea referring to the interfaith marriage of the petitioner, alleging that she was a minor at the time of the marriage. The actor has refuted the claim.

A.P., AstraZeneca ink pact for
genomic solutions centre

The Andhra Pradesh government on Tuesday signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with AstraZeneca India to establish an integrated genomic solutions centre in Amaravati, marking a major step towards precision cancer care. The initiative aims to create India's first integrated precision oncology research and treatment ecosystem, enabling personalised cancer diagnosis and treatment through advanced genomic technologies. It will provide advanced genomic testing and biomarker analysis for patients with lung and breast cancers.

Man booked for assaulting
four-year-old girl in Telangana

The Telangana police have booked a case against a 31-year-old man for allegedly sexually assaulting a four-year-old girl after luring her with chocolates. The suspect, identified as Ravi Kumar, is a resident of Mallikarjunagar. He was taken into custody after the child disclosed the alleged assault to her mother. The police said the incident occurred on July 26 at an apartment building near the area where the child was playing. Further investigation is under way.

Journey of faith



Devotees participate in the Gira Pradakshina of Sri Varaha Lakshmi Narasimha Swamy Temple at Simhachalam in Visakhapatnam, Andhra Pradesh, on Tuesday. As part of the centuries-old tradition, devotees undertake a 32-km circumambulation of the sacred hill. K.R. DEEPAK

Key aircraft
components
to be repaired
in Hyderabad

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

GMR Aero Technic, a aircraft maintenance service provider, has signed a licence agreement with Honeywell Aerospace to strengthen the country's aircraft maintenance, repair and overhaul capabilities.

Critical engine components used on Airbus A320neo and Boeing 737 MAX aircraft will now be repaired in Hyderabad.

Under the agreement, GMR Aero Technic will undertake work on seven Honeywell aerospace line replaceable units installed on LEAP engines that power the Airbus A320neo and Boeing 737 MAX fleets.

Study draws on Soligas in Karnataka to make
case against 'fortress conservation approach'

K.C. Deepika
BENGALURU

Wildlife conservation is typically achieved by excluding, evacuating or alienating the rights of indigenous people and local communities. A new research article published in the journal *Ecosystems and People* said this "fortress conservation approach" has led to uprooting, ongoing distress and despondency worldwide, and offers the Soligas in the Biligiri Rangaswamy Temple Wildlife Sanctuary a prime conservation exemplar.

Tribal people have been living with wild animals, especially tigers, leopards, elephants and managing forest resources for millennia in the sanctuary.



Living with the wild: The researchers engaged with Soliga elders to co-develop insights and solutions. FILE PHOTO

It highlighted the need to understand and recognise the importance of Adivasi people's connections, knowledge and skills in forest management.

The article, "Fortress conservation versus traditional forest management: The example of Soliga tri-

bal people from the Western Ghats, India" was published on Monday.

Engagement over years

The researchers engaged formally and informally with Soliga elders to co-develop insights and solutions for both conservation

and community needs.

Traditionally, the article said, Soligas managed the Biligiri area applying mosaic litter burning and small-scale swidden agriculture, without having to deal with noxious invasive weeds such as *L. camara*. People used to clear land for two to three years of cultivation, which subsequently enabled the colonisation of palatable grasses that served as food resources for various herbivores and, consequently, carnivores, especially tigers.

"The management of forests and related revered sacred and cultural values is integral to the Soligas' way of life," it said.

The article also noted that, Soliga elders expressed their aspirations to

Tamil Nadu
says released
water not
sufficient

T. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu has termed "insufficient" the release of 3,500 cubic feet per second (cusecs) of water for the next 15 days, as decided by the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee (CWRC). The State, according to its calculation based on deficient rainfall in the Cauvery's catchment, should have realised about 13 thousand million cubic feet (tmc ft) since June 1. However, it has received only around 3.5 tmc ft.

"As far as our workings are concerned, the shortfall is approximately 9.5 tmc ft, which could have easily been made good, given the combined storage of Karnataka's four reservoirs," a water expert in the State government said.

As of Tuesday, the storage was about 63 tmc ft as against a total capacity of 114.57 tmc ft.

If 3,500 cusecs is available throughout the day for 15 days, the quantum of water the State receives would be about 4.5 tmc ft. "In view of the storage in the neighbouring State, it would not be unreasonable to expect around 9 tmc ft from Karnataka, in which case the release has to be of the order of 7,000 cusecs," the expert said.

Thanga Jayaraman, a farmer from the Tiruvavur district, said Thiruvaiyaru's agriculturists had been requesting the State government to release a small quantity of water into the Cauvery river, at least for cattle.

Kerala teen affected
by amoebic brain
infection critical

The Hindu Bureau
KASARAGOD

Kasaragod district in Kerala has reported another case of amoebic meningoencephalitis (amoebic brain infection), with an 18-year-old testing positive for the rare but life-threatening disease. The teenager is in a critical condition at the intensive care unit of a hospital in Mangaluru.

According to preliminary information, the teen had bathed, along with his friends, in a pond located along the Kanhangad-Panathur State highway about a week ago. He developed health complica-

**The 18-year-old fell
sick after reportedly
taking bath in a
pond in Kasaragod**

tions soon afterwards, and subsequent tests confirmed the infection.

The Health Department and the police issued a warning directing people not to bathe in the pond until further notice. The authorities have also advised those who bathed in the pond to report to the nearest health centre. The pond is a popular bathing spot for local residents, students, and travellers.



Multiple petitions have accused police personnel of grave violations of constitutional guarantees. FILE PHOTO

Pleas in SC allege illegal detentions in Delhi and Bihar

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

Several petitions before the Supreme Court have alleged that police authorities in Delhi and Bihar resorted to “illegal and arbitrary detention” of individuals associated with the student protests against examination paper leaks, in “grave violation” of their constitutional guarantees.

An impleadment application, filed by Junaid Malik, who had volunteered to distribute food and water to protesters at Jantar Mantar, said he and his friend were picked up by Delhi Police personnel late on July 24.

The application, filed in the ongoing writ petition by Rajya Sabha member Manoj Jha against police excesses during the protests, further alleged that the two were blindfolded and detained at an undisclosed location overnight and repeatedly questioned by senior police officers about the source of funds used to distribute food and water at the protest site.

Mr. Malik has also alleged that a team of 10 to 12 Delhi Police personnel raided his residence on July 24, and demanded the bank account details and identity documents of all family members.

He has further claimed that another police team subsequently picked up his sister’s father-in-law and brother-in-law from their residence in Meerut the same day and took them to Masuri police station in Ghaziabad, where they were allegedly detained and questioned before being released later that evening following the intervention of their lawyers.

The application further contended that all these

actions were carried out without “any paperwork, diary entry, or any other official record” and amounted to a grave violation of the fundamental right to life and personal liberty guaranteed under Article 21 of the Constitution.

‘Grounds not furnished’
Another writ petition filed by a 22-year-old law student from Bihar has alleged that he was picked up by the police while participating in the protests on July 25 and remanded in judicial custody at Beur Central Jail in Patna. The petition claimed that he was never informed of the grounds of his arrest and was produced before the jurisdictional magistrate only after the expiry of the constitutional mandate of 24 hours.

The petition further alleged that he was subsequently arrayed as accused in an FIR which includes 5,000 “unknown persons”, without attributing any specific overt act to any of them.

On Monday, amid reports of detentions of demonstrators, the Bihar government announced that it had decided not to take any “punitive, retaliatory, or adverse legal action” against any person who had participated in the protests in the State prior to 6 p.m. on July 26, 2026.

The petition contended that, despite the Bihar government’s decision not to take any action against protesters, the law student was still in judicial custody, the petition said. It therefore urged the Supreme Court to intervene, contending that his continued “illegal detention” constituted “the most egregious violation of fundamental rights.”

RAF diary entry shows Delhi Police authorised pellet gun use on July 20

RAF registered entry at Parliament Street police station on July 22, soon after *The Hindu’s* report on pellet gun injuries; RAF later withdrew pump action guns, electric shields, anti-riot guns, shock batons from personnel deployed at Jantar Mantar

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

Days after the Delhi Police denied the usage of pellet guns during the July 20 march to Parliament – in which at least four persons reported being hit with pellets – a general diary entry filed at Parliament Street police station reveals that the Rapid Action Force (RAF) did fire two rounds from an anti-riot gun on the directions of a Deputy Commissioner of Police (DCP) rank officer.

The Hindu has accessed the general diary entry, which was registered by the RAF at 1.24 a.m. on July 22. This was the first time that a pellet gun was used against unarmed protesters in the national capital. Following the July 20 incident, the RAF withdrew shock batons, electric shields, pump-action guns, and the anti-riot guns, which fire pellets, from personnel deployed at Jantar Mantar. A review by an RAF Inspector-General also highlighted “serious deficiencies” in RAF behaviour during the march, in violation of its principle of “sensitive policing”.



RAF personnel deployed near the Parliament House during the CJP protest march in New Delhi on July 20. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

Two rounds fired

The diary entry says that, to control the crowd during the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) protest, “on the orders of Zone-I, DCP, Jantar Mantar,” the RAF Deputy Commandant fired “55 rounds of non-electrical shell, 15 rounds of electrical shell, five tear smoke grenade, two rounds using ballistic cartridges with plastic pellets from an anti-

riot gun.” The RAF, which is the anti-riot unit of the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF), was deployed and was under the operational control of the Delhi Police at the time of the incident.

The diary entry was made hours after *The Hindu* reported on July 21 that two people allegedly hit by pellets fired by RAF personnel had undergone surgery at government hospitals. One of them, Sahil Lochab, 19, risks losing vision in his right eye due to

a pellet piercing his pupil, his family said.

Police sources said that during a law-and-order situation, Central forces, in this case the RAF, are given a general consent by the police officer concerned, to use all crowd-control equipment at their disposal.

‘Serious deficiencies’

Significantly, in a video conference with RAF personnel after the incident, RAF Inspector-General Seema Dhundhia “gave clear directions that during the current Delhi deployment, the situation has been analysed and until further orders pump action guns (PAG), anti-riot Gun (ARG), electric shock weapon, and electric shield shall not be used or issued to personnel.”

The minutes of the meeting accessed by *The Hindu* said that “serious deficiencies were observed in many aspects of the operation, which need to be improved in the future.”

The Inspector-General reiterated that the core principle of the RAF is

MP moves SC over mass surveillance at protest

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Rajya Sabha MP A.A. Rahim moved the Supreme Court on Tuesday against the deployment of facial recognition technology and allied mass surveillance measures by the Delhi Police against students who participated in the Cockroach Janta Party-linked protests.

The petition sought a judicial declaration that such surveillance was unconstitutional. Mr. Rahim, represented by advocate Subhash Chandran, sought directions from the court to forthwith cease and desist from using facial recognition technology and other surveillance measures on peaceful protesters without a valid law.

SC hearing on pleas over NEET protests yet to reveal if police kept Ministry in the loop

NEWS ANALYSIS

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

Little has been said in the Supreme Court so far about instructions or consultations between the Delhi Police and the Union Home Ministry as violence unfolded in NEET-UG protests in the national capital on July 20.

The Supreme Court judgment of February 2012 in the *Ramlila Maidan Incident versus Home Secretary* refers to the then Delhi Police Commissioner’s affidavit that “as a matter of practice, Delhi Police keep the Ministry of Home Affairs duly informed in such matters”.

The judgment said the affidavit had reasoned that



The political executive’s role is expected to be a key issue in the ongoing court hearings.

the Ministry of Home Affairs”, and had kept them clued in on the decisions taken by senior police officers on the ground. Under Article 239AA of the Constitution, the Ministry has control over the Delhi Police.

Akin to Jallianwala Bagh
The stand of the political executive would be a crucial part of the Supreme Court hearings into the NEET-UG protests, especially with one of the petitions claiming that the police action on July 20 against students protesting peacefully was “no less than the atrocities of the Jallianwala Bagh”.

The Supreme Court, over the decades, has shown a keen awareness and concern about political influence over the police.

Twenty years ago, a Supreme Court judgment in the *Prakash Singh* case had cautioned against the overwhelming influence of the political executive over the police. The 2006 judgment had been based on a petition arguing that reducing the police to a mere tool in the hands of political masters would result in serious violations of the rights of the people.

The 2006 judgment had referred to a research paper ‘Political and Administrative Manipulation of the Police’ published in 1979 by Bureau of Police Research and Development, warning that “excessive control of the political executive and its principal advisers over the police has the inherent danger of making the police a tool for subverting the process of

law, promoting the growth of authoritarianism, and shaking the very foundations of democracy”. One of the issues mentioned was police conduct in large-scale civil unrest.

The *Prakash Singh* case judgment had elaborated that political influence over the police was a reality by quoting from an April 3 1997 letter of the then Home Minister to State governments.

The Union Home Minister, the judgment said, had exhorted the “great national importance to insulate the police from the growing tendency of partisan or political interference in the discharge of its lawful functions of prevention and control of crime including investigation of cases and maintenance of public order”.

India’s Gen Z wants Pak. to end terror activities: govt.

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

India on Tuesday reiterated that Pakistan continues to promote cross-border terrorism as a state policy, with the External Affairs Ministry saying Pakistan’s Gen Z should “take note” that people of India, including the Indian Gen Z, are aware of Islamabad’s support for terrorism against India.

“Pakistan has been sponsoring cross-border terrorism against India for decades. The people of India, including Gen Z, have been demanding that the Pakistani state-sponsored cross-border terrorism must come to an end. We hope their counterparts are taking due note,” Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said, regarding the online support extended by the Pakistani social media handlers to student protesters at Jantar Mantar.

CBI files chargesheet against 13 accused in NEET paper leak case

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has filed a chargesheet against 13 arrested accused persons in the NEET-UG 2026 paper leak case, said the agency on Tuesday. All of them are currently in judicial custody.

The chargesheet comes days after BJP MP Dharmendra Pradhan resigned as Union Education Minister on July 25, in the wake of over a month-long agitation led by the Cockroach Janta Party.

The agency has invoked provisions related to criminal conspiracy, cheating, criminal breach of trust, destruction of evidence and other associated charges under the Prevention of Corruption Act, and the Public Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act.

It has cited 360 witness-

es, 422 documents, and 43 material objects in the chargesheet.

The agency registered the case based on a complaint lodged by the Department of Higher Education on May 12, alleging irregularities in the conduct of NEET-UG 2026 examination, which was held on May 3.

The CBI formed multiple teams with 72 officials and personnel, along with eight cyber forensic experts, to investigate the case. Searches were carried out at 92 locations in Delhi, Rajasthan, Maharashtra, and other States.

“These searches led to the seizure of incriminating material like digital and communication devices, documents etc. Forensic imaging and analysis of the material has been undertaken,” said the agency, adding that source of the leak was unearthed within weeks.

Truck full of stones found parked at protest site was in police custody, says report

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A truck loaded with stones that was found parked near Jantar Mantar ahead of the July 20 march to Parliament had been seized by the Delhi Police four days earlier and was in police custody when it appeared at the protest site and later outside the Indian Youth Congress (IYC) office, according to a *NewsLaundry* report published on Tuesday.

The Delhi Police, however, said claims alleging that the truck was deliberately deployed near Jantar Mantar or outside any political party office were “false and misleading”.

On July 20, Cockroach Janta Party founder Abhijeet Dipke had pointed out a truck loaded with stones parked near the protest site and demanded an explanation from the Delhi

Delhi Police say any claim that truck was deliberately stationed near Jantar Mantar is false and misleading

Police on how it crossed the police cordon and reached the site. “It could have been used to frame the protesters or incite violence,” Mr. Dipke said.

The *NewsLaundry* report stated that the truck was found outside the IYC office on Raisina Road on July 25 and had reportedly been parked there since July 21.

According to the report, the truck loaded with stones was taken into the custody of the Delhi Police after it collided with a van on July 16 at the Piroz Shah Road-Kasturba Gandhi Marg crossing. Both vehicles were brought to the *malkhana* (storage facility)

of the Sansad Marg police station. The report quoted an officer at the Sansad Marg police station as saying that the truck was parked right outside the station until July 20. After a video of it being parked at the protest site went viral, the police took the truck to Bhalswa, emptied it, brought it back and parked it at the same spot again.

The Delhi Police, in a statement said, “The truck was seized on July 16 in connection with FIR No. 65/2026 following a road accident involving the truck and a van... The vehicle was initially parked near the Parliament Street police station for safe custody due to space constraints. Considering the law and order arrangements for the ‘Chalo Sansad’ march, it was later emptied and shifted to a safer location in the early hours of July 20.”

Meta apologises for removing PM’s video addressing students

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Centre has sought a formal explanation from Meta after Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s video was briefly taken down by Facebook owing to what an automated platform alert initially described as a “legal request”.

In the video posted on 23 July, Mr. Modi sought to reassure students that his administration was taking firm action on NEET examination paper leaks. A source familiar with the matter told *The Hindu* that the post had been mistakenly flagged by an automated moderation tool designed to filter AI-generated content. Facebook’s parent company is said to have apologised for the error.

“The content was removed in error and has since been restored,” a Meta spokesperson said. It is



Narendra Modi

understood that the government has summoned a senior executive from Meta’s policy and government relations team to explain the error.

As *The Hindu* reported earlier this year, India is now among a small group of nations where government take-down requests are processed automatically. X, formerly Twitter continues to contest many take-down notices it receives under the Section 79 (3)(b) of the IT Act.

Paper leak Bill a milestone, says govt.; Opposition calls it 'cosmetic exercise'

Priyanka, Venugopal seek accountability for police action on NEET protesters

He questioned the education model where “coaching has become indispensable, students have to approach courts for justice, protesters face police violence, and degrees no longer guarantee jobs”.

DMK reiterates demand to scrap NEET, accuses Centre of ignoring concerns of T.N.

Joshi's appointment is an insult to our students, says Rahul



Congress's remarks on Pralhad Joshi are misleading, says BJP

“Before making such statements, Rahul Gandhi and Priyanka Vadra should have read and understood the facts properly. However, distorting statements for political convenience, misleading the country, and levelling baseless allegations has become a habit of the Congress party,” he said in the statement.

NCPI MPs participate in NDA Parliamentary Party meeting

‘Unwise to link women’s quota with delimitation’



"There should not be a penalty for good implementation of population policies, you can't have a noose around our neck, say that this is good for you (southern States), and stifle our voice," he said.



Protecting protest

Protests that inconvenience people must not be confused with violence

Defining feature of the recent Cockroach Janta Party agitation related to its under-estimation by the government, which hoped to quell the protests by force. The net result was widespread student anger, which served to entrench the agitation. The Supreme Court has just commenced hearing petitions on the police's alleged use of disproportionate force, especially on July 20 in Delhi and a constable's aerial firing of an assault rifle allegedly to disperse crowds on July 25 in Bihar's Siwan. The Court has also agreed to hear petitions from the families of police personnel claiming that they were assaulted and "lynched". The ferocity of the July 20 police crackdown against protesters is not in doubt; in addition to tear gas, videos also purported to show the police using lathis studded with nails. But as Justice Joymalya Bagchi observed, the state should also answer why some police officers allegedly lacked protective gear. Under-equipped police are more likely to escalate force out of fear, and this is why international best practices in crowd control involve graduated responses. There is also merit in pleas that the same police force accused of using excess force also investigating it could potentially undermine credibility.

However, the Chief Justice of India's remark that protests are permissible "with due permission and at designated places" could come at odds with the right to protest. The democratic purpose of a protest is to inconvenience the state and thus should not be limited to its happening at the state's convenience. At the same time, not every inconvenience is constitutionally protected. The answer lies in proportionality. If the CJI's insistence on 'discipline' comes to mean protests must be orderly and predictable, it risks imposing administrative preferences on a constitutional right. The state is responsible for preventing violence, protecting life, and maintaining essential services. But modern cities are also dense and even a peaceful blockade could deprive thousands of uninvolved citizens of their liberties. The judiciary should thus resist conflating disruption that results in inconveniencing the public – which is one of the mechanisms by which a protest acquires its political force – and violence, which infringes on the rights of others. A unified set of procedures will also be welcome since policing is a State subject under the Seventh Schedule, and States have different training, equipment, escalation, and documentation rules. A national protocol could standardise the thresholds at which the use of high-impact crowd-control measures can be authorised and mandatory documentation of lathi charges, medical assistance after use of force, preservation of evidence, and independent inquiries into serious injuries.

Diminishing relevance

The Commonwealth Games look increasingly like a relic from the past

As Olympic and World Championships medalist Mirabai Chanu stood atop the podium in Glasgow on Sunday, tears rolling down her cheeks after becoming the first woman weightlifter to secure her third consecutive Commonwealth Games gold medal, she provided much-needed succour to a Games that had risked fading into oblivion a few years ago. With India set to host the centenary edition of the Games in Ahmedabad in 2030, there could not have been a better advertisement than Mirabai's golden triumph, which also ensured her fourth medal of any colour in a row in the women's 48kg category with a total of 190kg. The seasoned weightlifter's feat may not be the only glorious chapter written in the Scottish city, as other leading Indian athletes are expected to climb the podium in athletics and para-athletics, weightlifting and para-weightlifting, boxing, judo, and lawn bowls and para-bowls. According to an internal estimation by the Union Sports Ministry, India's athletes are expected to win around 30 medals even though several disciplines in which Indians have traditionally excelled – such as wrestling, badminton, table tennis, hockey and squash – were dropped from the scaled-down Glasgow event. Medals are expected from Neeraj Chopra, Murali Sreesankar, Praveen Chithravel, and boxers Lovlina Borgohain and Jaismine Lamboria.

The curtailed Commonwealth Games highlights the diminishing relevance of the erstwhile British Empire's sporting tradition. The 2026 edition, originally allotted to Victoria, faced an existential threat after the Australian State withdrew as a host three years ago due to spiralling costs. Glasgow, the host in 2014, saved the Games from embarrassment by proposing a scaled-down version – with 10 integrated disciplines, across four venues within an eight-mile corridor. Even though the Commonwealth Games do not match the global or regional excellence of the Olympics or the Asian Games, the platform still holds a strong appeal for Indian sportspersons and administrators. While India's success at the elite world level across different sports has been sporadic, it has the dubious distinction of topping the global doping charts for three successive years. Multiple athletes across disciplines have been caught for consuming banned substances even in the run-up to Glasgow 2026. Either they have been withdrawn from the Indian contingent or have failed to qualify due to this, impacting the nation's medal chances and bringing it shameful international headlines. As the country prepares to organise a bigger Commonwealth Games – especially against the backdrop of the corruption-tainted Delhi 2010 edition – it would do well to enhance its vigilance to curb financial malpractices and promote clean sport over the next four years.

On June 22, 2026, 15 people gasped to death in a burning building in Aliganj, Lucknow. Trapped behind smoke-filled corridors and sealed exits, they never had a chance. The commercial establishment operating from a residential neighbourhood was a veritable death trap – pigeonhole-sized workstations crammed into an unauthorised structure with no viable fire escape.

It was not merely a building that caught fire, but a system that failed. A tragedy waiting to happen, aided by those whose job it was to prevent it.

All this happened, while the TV channels discussed animatedly U.S.-Iran parleys, where India played no role, and analysts dissected the number of Members of Parliament defecting to the Eknath Shinde-led Shiv Sena. Not aware if there was ever a mention of a collapse of political ethics and morality. But then, do ethics, morality and professionalism figure in urban governance today? Major fires have erupted in cities across India in 2026 on account of failures of urban regulation – signifying abject greed and mismanagement.

On June 3, a fire in a bed and breakfast facility, Malviya Nagar, Delhi, was also caused by illegal construction with no emergency exit. In February, a Bhiwadi garment plant, Rajasthan, which caught fire was an illegal firecracker-manufacturing unit behind closed doors; the fire in a cracker manufacturing unit in Virudhunagar, Tamil Nadu, took place when the factory was running illegally on a Sunday.

Yet, amidst the horror, emerged stories of extraordinary courage. In Delhi's Malviya Nagar fire, a mattress shop owner reportedly emptied his entire stock onto the street to cushion those jumping from the burning building. Young residents rushed forward without waiting for instructions, while police personnel administered CPR, evacuated victims and continued rescue efforts despite injuries to themselves. Such acts of humanity stand in sharp contrast to the institutional failures.

Historical data trends suggest that India sees approximately 13,000-15,000 fire deaths annually, with the summer of 2026 projected to be one of the worst due to extreme heatwaves triggering electrical fires. In the first quarter of 2026, 39 people have died in fires in Delhi alone, even before the summer peak began.

Violations without consequences

The problem extends far beyond Aliganj and Malviya Nagar. Death traps of varying forms exist in countless urban settlements across India. They may differ in appearance but share a common characteristic: everyone knows the violations exist, yet they continue.

This is what makes the present crisis particularly troubling when India today possesses technological capabilities unimaginable even a decade ago. Satellite imagery can identify encroachments. Drones can map illegal



Yashovardhan Azad

Retired Indian Police Service officer, who has served as the Central Information Commissioner, Secretary – Security, Government of India, and Special Director, Intelligence Bureau

Urban neglect, political apathy, and corruption continue to claim lives across India

constructions. Geographic Information Systems can track land use changes. Digital property databases can identify violations. Artificial intelligence can flag anomalies and real-time dashboards can monitor compliance.

Is it really difficult for a municipal commissioner, a development authority official, a State government functionary or the Lieutenant Governor to call for a list of establishments operating without licences, fire clearances or in myriad violations of building norms?

The difficulty lies elsewhere. It lies in political pressure and vote-bank calculations and in the thriving informal economies that governments are reluctant to confront and where urban laws and regulations are routinely violated. But, most importantly, it lies in corruption.

Could the fire in Lucknow have been averted? Yes. In 2016, a notice for demolition was given but within two months was withdrawn. It was clearly a political decision. The property stood out as a symbol of political patronage under benign oversight of officials, right in the midst of a prominent locality of the capital. This sends out a message to the lower officials, the enforcers, who then entrench a system of their own beneficiaries, overlooking various violations for monetary benefits.

The Special Investigation Team (SIT) formed to investigate the fire comprised two senior officers, from the IAS and the IPS from the State of Uttar Pradesh, with the report to be submitted to another IAS officer of the government. The head of Lucknow land development Authority is also an IAS officer. In such a situation, can the inquiry yield anything purposeful. If a calamity of this kind results only in a conversation between a closed loop of bureaucrats, can there ever be any meaningful reform? No. But it was certainly possible if the Minister of Urban Development and the head of the capital land development authority were indicted for this tragedy.

This pattern is visible across the country. In Noida, a young professional lost his life after falling into a waterlogged, poorly protected urban hazard. In Indore, celebrated nationally for cleanliness, deaths linked to contaminated water supply raise disturbing questions about basic civic safeguards. Bengaluru, India's technology capital, repeatedly grinds to a halt after heavy rains. Mumbai, India's financial capital, continues to struggle with flooding despite decades of investment and repeated expert recommendations.

A common thread

Different cities. Different governments. Different political parties, but the same outcome. The real concern is the absence of accountability and governance deficit. What happened after Delhi's basement coaching centre tragedy? Arrests were made. Committees were constituted. Headlines were generated. Yet, illegal and unsafe basement operations continue to flourish in many cities. How many inquiry reports have fundamentally

Iran's Afghan balancing act amid regional upheaval

The funeral proceedings of Iran's late Supreme Leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, that stretched over a week amid a spiralling war and significant internal turmoil at the seat of power for Shiism, saw multiple personalities visit Tehran. Almost unnoticed, however, was the presence of delegations from both the Taliban and the opposition Northern Alliance. The two have been fighting each other, in various iterations, over Afghanistan since the 1990s.

Complex equations

The presence of the Taliban's Deputy Prime Minister for Economic Affairs Mullah Abdul Ghani Baradar along with Taliban Foreign Minister Amir Khan Muttaqi on the one hand and the Northern Alliance's Ahmed Massoud, son of the group's founder Ahmed Shah Massoud on the other, highlighted the delicate game of geopolitics that continues to persist on Tehran's eastern front. While Iran is the one country which has built the strongest influence with Kabul since the collapse of the government of President Ashraf Ghani (August 2021), it still does not officially recognise the Taliban government. This is hardly surprising, considering that until the 1990s, Iran, along with India, Russia, Tajikistan and other neighbouring and foreign states, supported the Northern Alliance.

The chaotic withdrawal of the United States from Afghanistan, in August 2021, two decades after a post-9/11 war launched against al Qaeda was a critical moment in Tehran. The consistent and massive deployment of western military power on its borders was a perpetual nightmare that had to be factored into its calculations. Pakistan's support for and incubation of the Afghan Taliban, while simultaneously backing the U.S.-led 'war on terror', created a sinkhole of competing interests, where the Venn diagram of who was supporting whom became so



Kabir Taneja

Executive Director of the Observer Research Foundation Middle East

The events of 2021 on Iran's eastern front continue to influence Tehran's choices amid the war in 2026

convoluted that foreign powers often ceded the upper hand to regional players. The fact that al Qaeda founder Osama Bin Laden was eventually found in Abbottabad, Pakistan (May 2011), in a large house – and not a cave in the infamous Tora Bora – was not a coincidence.

The Afghan chessboard

The Iranian viewpoint on the Taliban and the Afghan landscape changed significantly after 9/11. While Tehran remains sceptical of the Taliban and the future of its rule to this day, it simultaneously recognises that an insurgency-turned-government will always carry a question mark over its long-term stability. The ideological and tribal fissures that persist also require micromanagement, which means creating enemies along volatile borders is not in anyone's long-term interests.

Following 2021, the Taliban was in search of both power and patronage. Iran could offer some of the patronage. The calculation behind this was to free up a major front from as much conflict as possible. The Northern Alliance, largely concentrated in the mountainous northern province of Panjshir, was both weak and disorganised, with infighting having hollowed out any possibility of cohesion and structure. In fact, since February, as clouds of war gathered, the Taliban reiterated that it would support Iran should the country come under attack. Zabihullah Mujahid, a spokesman close to Taliban emir Hibatullah Akhundzada, said in an interview with Iranian state radio that they would support Iran if need be. The nature and extent of such support, of course, remain subjects of debate. Diplomatic support from Kabul has been robust over the past year, including access to the country's civilian airports.

But the Iranians hosting Masood and the Northern Alliance delegation in Tehran shows

altered urban governance? How many officials have faced meaningful consequences years after disasters? How many systemic reforms have followed repeated tragedies? India has actually become adept at managing outrage and far less effective in preventing a recurrence of man-made tragedies.

At the heart of the problem lies a governance structure that nobody wishes to discuss honestly. For over three decades, since the 74th Constitutional Amendment, India has spoken of empowering urban local bodies. Yet, most city governments remain weak. Every Chief Minister is the de facto mayor for all cities in his/her State and municipal corporations have responsibility without authority. Elected representatives have visibility without power. Important functions remain scattered across development authorities, municipal corporations, public works departments, water boards, transport agencies and numerous specialised bodies.

A flooded road belongs to one agency, a drain to another, land to a third and enforcement to a fourth. Citizens, meanwhile, simply see government. This fragmentation has created a dangerous accountability vacuum.

Fix governance first

The answer therefore is not another scheme. Indian cities are already overflowing with schemes, missions, projects and programmes. Every few years a new initiative comes up with a new acronym and fresh funding. The problem is not the absence of schemes, but the absence of governance. A number of well-meaning schemes lie buried under corruption and mismanagement. Cities require empowered local institutions, professional urban management, clear accountability and fearless enforcement. Technology must become an instrument of compliance rather than a showcase of modernisation. Most importantly, governments must find the political courage to dismantle entrenched systems of tolerated illegality. Officers, the enforcers, look away fearing a clash with political vested interests.

The victims of Lucknow and Delhi fires did not die because India lacks fire safety laws. They died despite those laws. That is the distinction policymakers must understand. Urban governance is ultimately measured not by the number of projects inaugurated, smart-city dashboards installed or schemes announced, but by the number of tragedies prevented. The real test of governance is whether an ordinary citizen can work, live, study, shop or sleep in a building without fear of dying because somebody chose to ignore the rules.

Will this tragedy become yet another file, another enquiry and another forgotten headline? Or will it finally compel us to confront the uncomfortable truth that India's cities are not merely growing beyond their capacity but are increasingly failing the very citizens they were meant to serve?

that, despite the war in West Asia, Iran is not willing to put all its eggs in one basket when it comes to Afghanistan. The country, and its intricacies, remain a problem that needs strategic management. The fact that the Taliban is still prioritising solidifying its own power and structure, especially between Kabul, the political capital, and Kandahar, the ideological one, highlights that homogeneously supporting the group is still not seen as being wise. For Tehran, this geography remains critical. For example, Quds Force, the powerful Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps' (IRGC) elite external operations branch, has been run by Esmail Qaani since the assassination of Qasem Soleimani in 2020 by the U.S. Qaani, is known to be a Khorasan hand (Iran's north/eastern neighbours such as Afghanistan, Turkmenistan, among others). Qaani's operational history goes back to the Taliban versus Northern Alliance era of the 1990s.

Ties with Pakistan

The war currently engulfing West Asia is expected to remain a constant for at least a few months to come. Pakistan's role as a mediator between Tehran and Washington DC, has given a new lease of 'brotherhood' between the two. Nonetheless, their aims are divergent. For Pakistan, the objective is to get back into the good books of both the U.S. and Gulf partners (Islamabad now has troops stationed in Saudi Arabia). For Iran, it is about reaching out to the U.S. through a neighbour it knows, if not trusts, better than most. The Iran-Pakistan bilateral relationship is incidental to everything else.

Increasingly, no binaries exist in international diplomacy. Neither do brotherhoods. Every hug is exchanged with one eye always open. These realities predate contemporary politics in South Asia and West Asia, long before the disintegration of western power began to take the shape we are witnessing today.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Protest to politics

The Cockroach Janta Party's threat that fresh protests could erupt if the terms of the agreement with the government are not met may not find many takers, even among the youth and students. It should not be under the impression that all its protests will succeed.

The ruling dispensation has the power to quell unrest. Now that some political leaders have identified themselves with the CJP, it may develop a stronger political dependence for its survival. One would not be surprised if the CJP announces itself as a political party soon (Front

page, July 28).
V. Lakshmanan,
Tirupur, Tamil Nadu

Restore trust

The Union Government's decision to constitute a high-level task force is a welcome acknowledgment of the deep crisis of confidence surrounding

India's examination and higher education system. Equally reassuring is the appointment of Nandan Nilekani as its chair. His leadership in building Aadhaar and India's digital public infrastructure demonstrates his ability to combine technological innovation with institutional

reform. His vision can help the task force prepare India's education system for the demands of a rapidly evolving knowledge economy. However, the committee's success will depend on more than recommendations. The government must ensure transparent

implementation, clear timelines, measurable outcomes, and regular public accountability to restore trust among millions of aspiring students.

M. Jeyaram,
Sholavandan, Tamil Nadu

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Co-existing with tigers outside reserves

India's tiger conservation story is widely regarded as one of the world's most extraordinary wildlife recoveries – a species brought back from near extinction through sustained political commitment, scientific management, and decades of on-ground protection. Since the launch of Project Tiger in 1973, the country's network of protected areas has expanded from nine reserves covering 18,278 sq km to 58 reserves spanning 84,488 sq km, accounting for nearly 2.6% of India's landmass. India's tiger population has risen from 1,411 in 2006 to 3,682 in 2022, firmly establishing the country as home to over 70% of the world's wild tigers. This success has now created a new conservation frontier – the growing proportion of tigers living outside protected areas.

Although national datasets do not conclusively link rising tiger numbers with increasing human-tiger conflict, forest departments across several landscapes report a steady escalation in such incidents. As territorial carnivores require extensive home ranges, tigers disperse naturally when core habitats reach saturation. Consequently, more tigers are moving beyond protected boundaries into human-dominated fringes. According to the National Tiger Conservation Authority, 35-40% of India's tiger population now lives outside designated Tiger Reserves. This reality has prompted the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change to launch the Tigers Outside Tiger Reserves (TOTR) initiative.

Beyond protected boundaries
The growing tiger population reflects healthy breeding groups, functional habitats, and well-connected forest corridors. However, when tigers move beyond protected areas into landscapes interwoven with villages, farms, roads and other human infrastructure, interactions



Supriya Sahu
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The objective of the Tigers Outside Tiger Reserves initiative is to establish a scientifically grounded, landscape-based framework for conserving tigers outside protected areas while safeguarding human lives

with people become inevitable, leading to human fatalities, livestock depredation, accidental encounters, prolonged rescue operations, and heightened public anxiety. Each incident carries ecological, social, and political consequences, placing enormous pressure on forest departments and district administrations.

The objective of the TOTR is to establish a scientifically grounded, landscape-based framework for conserving tigers outside protected areas while safeguarding human lives and livelihoods. Rather than responding to conflict only after it occurs, the initiative seeks to shift the approach from reactive crisis management to proactive, science-driven governance built on technology, preparedness, and community participation.

The TOTR is being launched as a targeted pilot rather than a nationwide rollout, recognising that long-term policy must be anchored in evidence generated under real field conditions.

The All-India Tiger Estimation (2022) recorded tiger presence across 212 forest divisions. Based on this assessment, 40 forest divisions across nine States have been selected for the first phase of the TOTR implementation. The participating States include Uttarakhand, Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Telangana and Assam.

The TOTR rests on two complementary pillars. The first focuses on reducing human-tiger conflict and strengthening field protection. This includes upgrading communication systems, deploying rapid response teams, improving rescue infrastructure, and ensuring coordinated action during emergencies. The second pillar emphasises long-term coexistence. Conservation outside protected areas cannot succeed without the trust and participation of local communities. Awareness programmes, community engagement, timely compensation

and treating villagers as partners are central to the initiative. Tigers and people now co-occur across vast shared landscapes, making structured coexistence essential for long-term stability.

Among these, streamlined and timely compensation mechanisms are critical. Although States have their own frameworks, delays often erode public trust and fuel resentment. States must simplify procedures and invest in sustained outreach to build confidence among rural families living alongside tigers.

The role of States

Participating States will also need to invest strategically in both technology and institutional capacity. The programme rightly emphasises the use of modern conservation tools such as camera traps, GPS-enabled monitoring systems, drones and AI to strengthen surveillance, improve early warning systems and enable evidence-based decision-making. However, technology alone cannot resolve human-tiger conflict. Its effectiveness will ultimately depend on the strength of the institutions that support it. Building public confidence requires well-trained forest staff, veterinarians, and rescue teams capable of responding rapidly in conflict situations.

The TOTR underscores a broader national imperative: strengthening the governance of shared landscapes where ecological processes and human livelihoods intersect daily. The initiative signals a shift from viewing tiger conservation solely through the lens of protected areas to recognising the wider mosaic of reserve forests and other lands that now support dispersing tigers.

If executed with the same determination that made Project Tiger a global benchmark, the TOTR could become India's defining conservation initiative of the century proving that people and large carnivores can share space safely.

Need for moderation in public speech

Tamil Nadu's political arena has become a theatre of vitriolic discourse

STATE OF PLAY

M.S. Shanmugam

Mark Twain once said, “the difference between the almost right word and the right word is really a large matter.”

In recent times, public discourse in Tamil Nadu's political arena has come under scrutiny. Concerns are being raised across sections of society about the tone, content, and quality of speeches delivered by leaders from both the ruling and Opposition parties. Allegations, counter-allegations, legal actions, agitated debates on television channels and newspapers have become frequent, indicating not merely isolated incidents, but a worrying trend.

Political speech is not just a tool for mobilisation; it is a reflection of democratic culture. Furthermore, it is one of the most basic tools and features of democracy. It is how parties take their policies and views to the people. However, when language descends into personal attacks, provocation, or sensationalism, it sets a precedent. And a bad one at that.

History teaches us that while such precedents are easy to establish, they are exceedingly difficult to reverse.

Global precedents

The experience of the United States during the McCarthy era in the 1950s offers a telling lesson. Senator Joseph McCarthy's speeches, marked by sweeping allegations and dramatic accusations, created a climate of fear and mistrust. Careers were ruined, institutions were strained, and public discourse suffered.



It took a moment of collective introspection – captured in the famous question, “Have you no sense of decency, sir?” – to begin restoring balance. The damage, however, lingered far beyond that moment.

Similarly, in Europe, the final years of the Weimar Republic saw a steady decline in the quality of political speech. Increasingly harsh and polarising rhetoric eroded mutual respect among political actors and weakened democratic norms. What began as verbal aggression eventually contributed to a breakdown of stability itself.

The lesson was clear: words, when used unchecked, can shape outcomes far beyond immediate political gains.

Leaders shape discourse

In a mature democracy, citizens expect more from their leaders. They look for clarity of vision rather than clever invective; for solutions rather than slogans; and for dignity even in disagreement.

Political speech must inform, inspire, and unify – not inflame or divide. The divisive and exclusive, as opposed to inclusive, trends in speeches are causing deep concerns at the local as well as the global level.

Moderation in speech is

not a sign of weakness; it is a mark of strength and responsibility. It reflects confidence in one's ideas and respect for the audience. When there is solid substance, the words spoken become the natural foundation on which to reach the people.

Leaders at all levels set the tone for public behaviour. When they uphold dignity, society follows. When they abandon it, the consequences ripple outward to the last man.

At this juncture, there is an opportunity for all stakeholders – across party lines – to pause and reflect. Reaffirming norms of respectful discourse, setting internal standards for communication, and prioritising public interest over momentary applause can help restore balance. Media needs to play a crucial role by not promoting or repeating sensational utterances for increasing their viewership.

For the next generation

Democracy thrives not merely on the freedom of speech, but on the wisdom with which that freedom is exercised. The younger generation, the future of the country, must be inspired by principled political discourse. When leaders speak with integrity and purpose, they not only shape public opinion and culture but also motivate young citizens to strive for excellence and grow into worthy contributors to the nation.

The need of the hour therefore is, not louder voices, but moderated ones – grounded in dignity, guided by responsibility, and committed to the larger good.

The author is a former IAS officer of the Tamil Nadu cadre.

Over 70% of police back immunity for using force

Official data on injuries sustained during police operations contradict numbers presented in news coverage and reports

DATA POINT

Devvyanshi Bihani
Nitika Francis
Gandla Sneha

The police response to the Cockroach Janta Party's (CJP) “Chalo Sansad” march earlier this week has once again put the spotlight on the powers of the police. As videos showing tear gas, pellet guns, and lathi charges circulated widely, questions resurfaced over when force may be used, the safeguards governing arrests, and the balance between maintaining public order and exercising civil liberties. Under the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), force may be used to disperse an unlawful assembly only after an order to disperse is disobeyed, while the National Human Rights Commission's Manual on Human Rights for Police Officers requires officers to rely on persuasion, advice and warning, using only minimum force when force becomes unavoidable. Yet the Status of Policing in India Report 2025, which surveyed 8,276 police personnel across 17 States and UTs, suggests that many in the police favour broader coercive powers.

One of the most striking findings was that more than 70% of respondents agreed that police should be allowed to use force without fear of punishment in order to properly discharge their responsibilities (**Chart 1**). Nearly as many (69%) believed that the police should be allowed to arrest and detain suspected criminals without any court investigation, revealing a tendency to exercise power arbitrarily (**Chart 2**).

Further, more than half of the respondents (55%) considered it either “very” or “somewhat” important for the police to use “tough methods” to create fear among the public (**Chart 3**). Around two-thirds said that public pressure influences the police to

deal with suspected criminals with a “heavy hand”. Nearly half of the respondents (48%) said that more preventive arrests of “anti-social elements” would be very useful in reducing crime (**Table 1**).

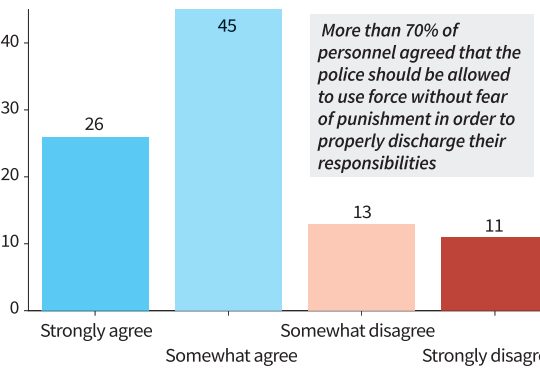
The survey's findings also raise questions about the perceptions of due process after arrest. Only 41% of police personnel said that statutory arrest procedures are always followed. These include informing the arrested person of the grounds of arrest, preparing arrest and inspection memos, notifying family members, ensuring a medical examination, and informing the accused of the right to contact a lawyer. One in five believed private consultation of the arrested with their lawyers should never be permitted. These findings offer a glimpse into institutional attitudes, their misalignment with legal frameworks, and the need for sensitising police on use of force.

The report notes that “India's otherwise robust crime data begins to waver when it comes to incidents of torture or deaths in custody” and that the available data is “inaccurate and inconsistent”. The past few editions of the National Crime Record Bureau's (NCRB) ‘Crime in India’ report have shown a declining number of civilians injured during police operations despite the occurrence of many widely reported incidents.

For instance, the NCRB says only 76 civilians were injured during police operations in India in 2020 despite the beginning of the year witnessing widespread protests against the Citizenship Amendment Act, particularly in north-east Delhi. A report by the UN High Commissioner for Human Rights states that over 200 were injured in Delhi alone. Another case of underreporting was in 2024, when only two civilians were injured during police operations, as per the NCRB. The ‘Dilli Chalo’ protests organised by farmers in that year resulted in police resorting to using force on many occasions (**Chart 4**).



Chart 1: “To properly fulfil their responsibilities, police should be allowed to use force without any fear of punishment” (Values in %)



The police beat

The Status of Policing in India 2025 report offers glimpses into the institutional attitude of the police in the country and the need for reforms. The charts below show the responses of the police personnel surveyed for the report for the questions mentioned in the respective charts

Brutality of power: Police personnel carry out a lathi charge on protesters during the “Chalo Sansad” march from Jantar Mantar to Parliament against the NEET paper leak, in New Delhi on July 20.

Chart 2: “Should the police be allowed to arrest and detain suspects without court investigation?” (Values in %)

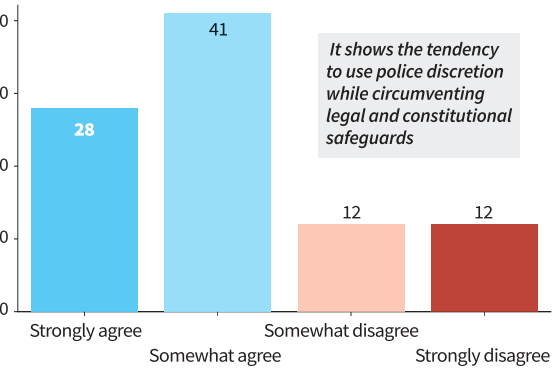


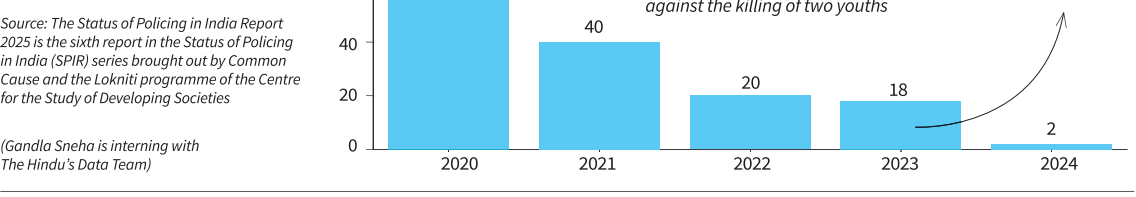
Chart 3: The importance of using tough methods to create fear (Values in %)



Table 1: Police personnel's views on the usefulness of various crime-control measures (Values in %)

Measures for crime control	Very useful	Somewhat useful	Not much useful	Not at all useful
Increasing the presence of beat police and /or patrolling or the number of police stations/chowkis	64	25	7	2
Recruiting more women into the police	58	26	10	5
More preventive arrests of “anti-social elements”	48	36	10	5
Forming special squads that can detain people indefinitely	43	28	15	12

Chart 4: Civilians injured during riots due to police firing and lathi charge in India as per NCRB



Source: The Status of Policing in India Report 2025 is the sixth report in the Status of Policing in India (SPIR) series brought out by Common Cause and the Lokniti programme of the Centre for the Study of Developing Societies

(Gandla Sneha is intern with The Hindu's Data Team)

Reports from PTI states that more than 30 students, mostly women, were injured in Manipur's Imphal Valley as the police fired tear gas shells and baton-charged a crowd protesting against the killing of two youths

FROM THE ARCHIVES



FIFTY YEARS AGO JULY 29, 1976

The King comes to the park

Madras, July 28: The Madras Snake Park, Guindy, has a new addition – a King Cobra. It was caught in the North Andamans rain forest on June 15 by Mr. Romulus Whitaker, Honorary Director of the Park. Since coming to Madras on July 1, it has been housed in a special enclosure, where its natural habitat is simulated.

A King Cobra brought to the Snake Park from Thailand died after seven months. Another from Karnataka also did not survive for long. Hence efforts are being made to air condition the enclosure. Visitors can see it moving in the cooler hours of the day.

According to Mr. Whitaker, the King Cobra is found only in certain rain forests and in extreme estuarine mangrove swarms of the Sunderbans (Bengal), the Bhitarkanika sanctuary on the Orissa coast, and the Western Ghats.

Twelve to 15 inches long when hatched, King cobras can grow to a maximum length of 19 feet, with a girth of about five inches. The female lays about 20 eggs at a time, and the hatching takes about two months. (The snake brought to Madras is a female).

The King Cobra is not a true cobra, though it is also poisonous. It is not of the same genus as the common cobra.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO JULY 29, 1926

The Czar's fortune

A special cable to “The Times of India” from London, dated July 26th states:—

A former attache at the Czar's court informs certain Italian newspapers that Czar Nicholas deposited a fortune in London on the outbreak of war of which, despite withdrawals to alleviate Russian distress, £12,000,000 plus interest remains.

The Czar's surviving relations desire King George or ex-King Manuel to arbitrate its disposal but cannot legally prove the Czar is dead.

“The Daily News” says inquiries in Russian and British Diplomatic circles do not confirm or deny the report. Although the sum may be exaggerated it must be remembered that the Kaiser before abdication saved half a million sterling yearly. The Soviet Embassy is sceptical. They admit large sums of Czarist money exist in London. General Koltchak sent to London £3,000,000 of Russian State funds when he captured Kazan.

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Number of e-Zero FIRs registered in Delhi since May 2025

6,115 Delhi has recorded the highest number of e-Zero FIRs among the 18 States and Union territories that have implemented the system for cyber financial fraud cases, the government informed Parliament on Tuesday. Delhi registered 6,115 e-Zero FIRs since implementing the system in May 2025. PTI

Cumulative cost overrun registered by infrastructure projects

4.92 in ₹ lakh crore. Infrastructure projects worth above ₹150 crore each registered a cumulative cost overrun of around ₹4,92,752 crore, as per a govt. report for June 2026. A total of 1,847 ongoing projects were monitored and it was found that the total revised cost was ₹40,54,473 crore compared to their original cost of ₹35,61,721 crore. PTI

Number of Meghalaya voters marked under ASDD category

1.5 lakh. Nearly 1.5 lakh electors in Meghalaya have been marked under the absent, shifted, dead and duplicate (ASDD) category during the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, the Chief Electoral Officer B.D.R. Tiwari's office said on Tuesday. A total of 1,49,656 electors, (6.37% of the State's electorate) fall under this category. PTI

Minimum balance penalties collected by private sector banks

4,949 in ₹ crore. Private sector banks have collected ₹4,948.71 crore from account holders for failing to maintain minimum average balance in their current accounts and savings accounts in FY26, Parliament was informed on Tuesday. During the period under review, public sector banks collected ₹2,137.92 crore for the same. PTI

Number of Ayushman cards generated under the AB-PMJAY

44.73 crore. More than 44.73 crore Ayushman cards have been created under the Ayushman Bharat-Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (AB-PMJAY), while over 12.69 crore hospital admissions worth ₹1.92 lakh crore have been authorised under the scheme, the Parliament was told on Tuesday. PTI

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Curbs on panchayat powers in Bengal

The Suvendu Adhikari govt. recently removed panchayat pradhans' powers to issue birth and death certificates. It also passed a law transferring financial disbursement rights from elected gram pradhans to panchayat secretaries and other officials. The moves signal increasing bureaucratic involvement in local self-governance.

EXPLAINER

Shiv Sahay Singh

In the last week of July 2026, the Bharatiya Janata Party government in West Bengal stripped the elected heads of panchayats of administrative and financial powers. On July 23, 2026, a State government notification stated that gram panchayat pradhans and municipal chairpersons will transition out of their previous roles as registrars regarding birth and death registrations. The Suvendu Adhikari government said that dedicated government officers would be appointed as registrars for every gram panchayat and municipality to streamline record-keeping of birth and death certificates and administrative workflows.

The very day the notification was issued, the State's Chief Secretary, Manoj Agarwal, held a press conference stating that there were irregularities in the issuance of birth certificates during the special intensive revision (SIR). The police held raids at several municipalities and civic bodies, where it seized birth and death records.

The State government argued that the move was aimed to ensure transparency in public service and curb corruption in the issuance of birth and death certificates. Birth and death certificates have been a contentious issue, particularly after an SIR, which removed about 12% of voters in West Bengal. Since the newly elected government has made it a priority to identify and deport illegal immigrants from Bangladesh, having officials oversee birth and death certificates appeals to the State government more than leaving the responsibility with elected representatives.

Deprived of financial powers

The West Bengal Legislative Assembly on Saturday passed the West Bengal Panchayat (Second Amendment), 2026 Bill, depriving elected representatives of



Bengal's BJP govt. stripped the elected panchayat heads of administrative and financial powers. PTI

panchayats of financial powers.

The legislation seeks to amend several provisions of the West Bengal Panchayat Act, 1973, with Section 6 transferring cheque-signing and financial disbursement rights from elected gram pradhans to panchayat secretaries, executive assistants, and block development officers. The statement of objects and reasons of the Bill said that the legislation was brought to ensure stability of panchayat bodies for the time-bound delivery of services.

Participating in the discussion on the bill, Panchayat Affairs and Rural Development Minister Dilip Ghosh said that the legislation does not intend to curtail the constitutional powers of elected panchayat heads. "Rather, it is aiming at curtailing the authority for corruption and commission against rural civic services. Henceforth, the elected panchayat heads will only approve any proposal. But the bill (financial bills/cheques) will be cleared and sanctioned by the bureaucrats," he said.

The Minister alleged that in many instances, pradhans have refused to sign work-related documents due to issues regarding alleged 'cut-money' (kickbacks).

He stated that the objective of the amendment is to curb such irregularities. Mr. Ghosh claimed that among all States in the country, it is only in West Bengal that panchayat pradhans possess such financial powers, and that economic interests have been a major factor behind the violence witnessed during panchayat elections.

Historical significance

West Bengal was among the first States in the country to implement a three-tier panchayat system. Almost two decades before the 73rd Constitutional Amendment of 1993, which officially gave constitutional status to the panchayati raj system in rural India, establishing a uniform three-tier local government structure, West Bengal had in 1973 passed a panchayat act, and the first panchayat elections were held in June 1978. With welfare schemes delivered at the panchayat level, gram panchayat members and pradhans gained enormous power. The control over local panchayats meant control over resources of the State.

With panchayats playing a crucial role in the delivery of public services, corruption and violence slowly crept in.

The last panchayat elections in West Bengal, held in 2023, witnessed widespread violence, with inter-party and intra-party clashes resulting in over 50 deaths. The previous elections during the Trinamool Congress and Left Front regimes also witnessed large-scale violence. The control over local resources and area domination by holding power in panchayats had become a hallmark of rural societies in West Bengal.

The fall of the Trinamool regime had brought to the fore widespread corruption at the panchayat level. The gram pradhan and elected panchayat representatives used to charge kickbacks for the delivery of services. The widespread public anger against the pradhans and elected members of panchayats after the change in the regime reflected the corruption in the system.

The politics behind powers being curtailed

After the BJP victory in the Assembly polls, the space occupied by the Opposition, particularly the Trinamool, has crumbled. Twenty of the 28 MPs have joined the Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI), and 65 of the 80 MLAs have split, claiming to be the real Trinamool Congress. What has largely remained untouched by the defections is the three-tier panchayat system in the State, comprising 3,317 gram panchayats with 63,000 elected members, 341 panchayat samitis with over 9700 elected members, and about 20 zilla parishads with 970 members. Almost 90% of the elected representatives at the three-tier panchayats are from the Trinamool. A significant majority of them have stopped performing their responsibilities, fearing public anger and the possibility of being booked in corruption cases.

The next panchayat election will be held in 2028. Therefore, the BJP government has decided to allocate administrative and financial powers to officials instead of elected gram panchayat heads, a move that will increase bureaucratic intervention in local self-governance.

THE GIST

West Bengal was among the first States in the country to implement a three-tier panchayat system. With welfare schemes delivered at the panchayat level, gram panchayat members and pradhans gained enormous power.

A provision of the West Bengal Panchayat (Second Amendment), 2026 Bill seeks to transfer financial disbursement rights to panchayat secretaries, executive assistants, and block development officers.

Will the govt. relax rules on airport-airline ownership?

Has the Adani Group's MoU with Embraer prompted the Centre's rethink on cross-ownership rules?

Jagriti Chandra

The story so far:

Following a request from the Adani Group, the Ministry of Civil Aviation is examining whether to relax cross-ownership restrictions between airport operators and airlines. Officials are preparing a concept note for consultations with the NITI Aayog and other government ministries before any proposal is taken to the Union Cabinet.

What is the government proposing?

The restrictions under review are embedded in airport concession agreements rather than in legislation. The concession agreements for Delhi and Mumbai airports cap aggregate airline ownership in the airport operator at 10%, while those for the Noida International Airport (Jewar) and Navi Mumbai airports

allow up to 26% ownership in an airline. These provisions can also be applied in reverse, effectively restricting airport operators such as Adani from acquiring significant stakes in airlines.

While the Adani Group denied media reports and said it had no interest in entering the airline business, a separate report cited a letter from Adani Airports CEO Arun Bansal stating that Adani Defence and Aerospace "was evaluating participating in the airline business to play a meaningful role in bridging connectivity in tier-2 and tier-3 cities". Government officials have latched on to this rationale, arguing that amending the cross-ownership rules would enable new airline entrants and help break the near-duopoly of IndiGo and the Air India group in the domestic market.

The interest comes at a time when the Adani Group has signed an MoU with Brazilian aircraft manufacturer Embraer

to explore local production of passenger aircraft. Embraer has said that setting up a final assembly line (FAL) in India would depend on securing a substantial aircraft order from the country.

How will concerns be addressed?

The current concession agreements maintain a separation between airport operators and airlines to prevent potential conflicts of interest by ensuring airports remain neutral infrastructure providers and do not favour affiliated carriers in gate allocation, terminal access, airport facilities or other operational decisions.

Government officials say any relaxation of the rules is likely to be accompanied by safeguards to ensure an "arm's length" relationship between airport and airline businesses. Among the measures under consideration are provisions preventing the direct or indirect sharing of commercially sensitive information,

including data relating to slot allocation and airport operations. The proposal is also expected to prohibit common key managerial personnel from holding executive positions in both the airport and airline entities.

The Adani Group is already the largest airport operator in the country with 8 airports in its kitty. It also has a 99.98% stake in maintenance, repair and overhaul company Airworks, has an agreement to acquire a 72.8% stake in pilot training organisation Flight Simulation Technique Centre, ground handling, retail and food and beverage concessions at airports.

How have airlines reacted?

India's two largest airline groups – IndiGo and Air India – have opposed the reported move, arguing that allowing airport operators to own airlines would create conflicts of interest and weaken competition.

IndiGo Managing Director Rahul Bhatia said there was "no global precedent because it would typically raise a massive conflict of interest, and over a period of time it would go against the interest of consumers."

Air India has expressed similar reservations. A senior executive told *The Hindu* that "vertical consolidation" in aviation is problematic, pointing to the Adani Group's presence across multiple segments of the aviation value chain.

According to the executive, ownership across so many parts of the ecosystem could disadvantage competing airlines and ultimately reduce competition and employment in the sector.

What are some global examples of such cross ownership?

While common ownership between airports and airlines exists in jurisdictions such as Singapore, Qatar and the UAE, these examples largely involve government ownership of both entities.

In Singapore, both Changi Airport Group and Singapore Airlines are ultimately owned by the government, with Temasek Holdings holding a majority stake in Singapore Airlines, while Qatar owns both Hamad International Airport and Qatar Airways, and the government of Dubai owns Dubai Airports and Emirates.

These examples differ from India in that each has one dominant state-backed flag carrier that anchors the hub airport, rather than multiple privately owned domestic carriers competing at privately operated airports. India's proposal, by contrast, would permit common ownership in a competitive market with multiple privately owned airlines, raising concerns over potential conflicts of interest and whether airport operators could accord preferential treatment to affiliated carriers.

INBRIEF



LIC appoints Shatmanyu Shrivastava as CFO

LIC on Tuesday announced the appointment of Shatmanyu Shrivastava as Executive Director (Finance & Accounts) and Chief Financial Officer. Previously he was Executive Director (Enterprise Risk Management) and Chief Risk Officer. His appointment follows the resignation of CFO Sunil Agrawal. LIC also announced the appointment of Varadarajan Muthuvenkataraman as Executive Director (Enterprise Risk Management) and Chief Risk Officer.

Former SBI CGM to liquidate Paytm Payments Bank Ltd.

The Delhi High Court has appointed former SBI chief general manager (CGM) Girikumar M. Nair to liquidate Paytm Payments Bank after the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) cancelled its banking licence three months ago. “As per the said Order, the Official Liquidator shall exercise all the powers prescribed under the provisions of the Banking Regulation Act, 1949 along with applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013,” the RBI said in a circular.

Ampere partners with Muthoot Capital Services

Ampere, the electric two-wheeler brand of Greaves Electric Mobility Limited, said it was partnering with Muthoot Capital Services to make electric mobility ownership more accessible and affordable. “We aim to remove financial barriers, empower customers with greater choice and convenience, and accelerate the adoption of clean mobility,” said Manoj M. P., Chief Business Officer, Greaves Electric Mobility.

City Union Bank Q1 net rises 25% to ₹383 crore

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

City Union Bank (CUB) reported a 25% year on year (YoY) rise in net profit to ₹383 crore in Q1. Interest income rose 24% to ₹1,985 crore during the quarter while interest expenses rose 19% to ₹1,165 crore. Net interest income (NII) grew 31% to ₹820 crore. Other income was almost same at ₹244 crore. Advances grew 25% to ₹67,645 crore while deposits climbed 21% to ₹79,342 crore. As of June 30, total business stood at ₹1.47 lakh crore, up 23%. Retail, agriculture and MSME portfolio accounted for 80% of the bank's total advances.

‘Indian space technology firms raised \$200 mn in 2025 led by Bengaluru’

Shilpa Elizabeth
BENGALURU

As India's space tech funding reached a record \$200 million in 2025 with Bengaluru emerging as the ecosystem leader attracting more than half of the money, as per market research firm Tracxn. Tracxn said in a report the sector raised about \$871 million as of July. The top 10 most-funded firms alone account for over 60% of this total, led by India's space tech unicorn, Skyroot Aerospace at \$150 million. Skyroot built Vikram-1, India's first privately developed orbital-class rocket, which successfully reached low Earth orbit on

Across the sea



Battery fleet: Yutong electric double-decker buses for export to the United Kingdom are driven onto a car carrier at Yantai Port in Shandong province, eastern China on Monday. AFP

India curtailed 8,133 GWh solar power to maintain grid security

As on June 30, India's installed solar power capacity stood at 162.15 GW, which included 30.11 GW of rooftop projects, 6.43 GW of off-grid project

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

India curtailed 8,133 gigawatt-hour (GWh) of solar power during the April-June quarter this year, according to Minister of State for New and Renewable Energy Shripad Yesso Naik. The curtailment and restriction were instituted to “maintain grid security” and “due to mismatch between commissioning of transmission lines and renewable energy projects, he informed Parliament, quoting figures from the Grid Controller of India. Curtailment is when power-grid operators limit the power output from generating sources to maintain grid stability. A total of 2,417 GWh of solar energy curtailment was carried out in April this year, 3,235 GWh in

Wasted energy

Restriction due to mismatch between commissioning of transmission lines and renewable energy projects, MoS tells House



- Curtailment is when power-grid operators limit output from generating sources
- 2,417 GWh of solar energy curtailment was carried out in April this year
- 3,235 GWh of solar energy was restricted in May and 2,481 GWh in June

May and 2,481 GWh in June. As on June 30, India has installed solar capacity of up to 162.15 GW, which is inclusive of 125.6 GW of utility scale projects, 30.11 GW of rooftop projects and 6.43 GW of off-grid projects.

PM Surya Ghar

Separately, Mr. Naik also told the upper house that since its implementation in February 2024, the PM Su-

rya Ghar scheme has received more than 75 lakh applications, as on July 22. More than 39.7 lakh rooftop solar (RTS) systems with a cumulative installed capacity of 14,180.90 MW have been installed, he added. Mr. Naik also said the scheme has reached out to more than 48 lakh households having released ₹27,343.9 crore as Central Financial Assistance (CFA) until June 27.

India, strongest growth market for Germany

Gurmehar Kaur
NEW DELHI

With India emerging as one of its strongest growth markets, the German National Tourist Office (GNTÖ) has unveiled its four campaign themes for this year, while Germany's national carrier Lufthansa

confirmed a €3 billion investment to lift its India-bound fleet, including doubling the capacity in its Mumbai-Munich route by upgrading it with an Airbus A380. The Lufthansa group is also expanding its India network through Swiss International Air Lines, which will begin fly-

ing Zurich to Bangalore, its newest India route. These announcements came as GNTÖ unveiled four campaign themes for 2026 – culture, city life, cuisine and nature, and as Lufthansa marked its 100th year of operations. Kevin Markette, Senior Director, Sales, South Asia,

HUL shares plummet 7% as Q1 PAT declines 3% to ₹2,673 crore

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Shares of Hindustan Unilever Ltd. (HUL) plunged 7% on the Bombay Stock Exchange (BSE) on Wednesday as the company's quarterly results fell short of investors' expectations, even as it saw higher revenues. HUL's first-quarter net profit fell 3% year-on-year (YoY) to ₹2,673 crore due to one-off tax credit gain made in the year-earlier period. Rising input costs and inflationary pressures remained key challenges, affecting operating margins during the quarter. However, the company delivered the highest revenue growth in 13 quarters, with underlying sales growth (USG) of 10%, supported by higher sales volumes and selective price increases. USG refers to the increase in turnover for the period, excluding any change resulting from acquisitions and disposals. Revenue from sales



Revenue from sales jumped 10.26% YoY to ₹17,149 crore

jumped 10.26% YoY to ₹17,149 crore. “Despite global geopolitical volatility, the Indian economy demonstrated resilience, supported by proactive fiscal and monetary policy measures. The underlying demand environment remained stable during the quarter. Against this backdrop, HUL delivered a turnover of ₹17,184 crore and 10% USG, driven equally by volume and price. This marks our highest growth in thirteen quarters,” said Priya Nair, CEO and MD, HUL. Analysts said that the company's performance reflected resilient consumer demand, particularly in rural markets.

L&T Q1 consolidated net up 14% to ₹4,123 cr.

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Larsen & Toubro Ltd. (L&T) for the first quarter ended June 30, 2026 posted a consolidated profit after tax (PAT) of ₹4,123

ONGC okays \$500 mn PCG for MRPL for Saudi Aramco crude import

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

State-owned Oil and Natural Gas Corp (ONGC) said on Tuesday that it had approved a \$500-million parent company guarantee (PCG) in favour of Saudi Aramco on behalf of subsidiary Mangalore Refinery and Petrochemicals Ltd. (MRPL) enabling them to import crude oil from Saudi Aramco. “The board of directors, at its meeting held today has inter-alia approved the proposal to provide parent company guarantee (PCG) of \$500 million in favour of Saudi Arabian Oil Company (Saudi Aramco) for the period 01.09.2026 to 31.08.2028 on behalf of (MRPL), to enable MRPL to import crude oil from Saudi Aramco,” ONGC informed the bourses in an exchange filing. The guarantee would be applicable for a period of approximately two years, i.e., between September 1, 2026 and August 31, 2028.

Air India FY26 loss more than doubles to ₹22,238 crore

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Air India's financial turnaround effort suffered a major setback in FY26 with the privatised airline reporting a net loss of ₹22,238 crore, more than double it suffered in FY25, according to Tata Sons Annual Report. Revenue slid to ₹70,081 crore from ₹76,754 crore, due to scaled down operations amid geopolitical developments. Singapore Airlines, holding 25% stake in Air India, reported a Q1 loss of \$58.7 million, the first loss since 2022 when it was impacted by COVID-19. Singapore Airlines' quarterly losses were attributed to steep hike in jet



Air India's revenue dropped to ₹70,081 cr. from ₹76,754 cr.

fuel prices and mounting losses at Air India. In his message to shareholders, Tata Sons chairman N. Chandrasekaran described FY26 as the airline's ‘most challenging year’ since its acquisition by the Tata Group in January 2022 and attributed the

deteriorating financial performance to a combination of geopolitical tensions, operational disruptions and one-off events that significantly affected the airline's operations. “Given where it began, Air India's transformation must be seen as a five-to-ten-year journey,” he said, indicating the turnaround, planned as a five-year programme under the Vihann.AI strategy, could now extend up to a decade. **Tata Sons net rises** Meanwhile for FY26, Tata Sons' revenue rose 9.1% to ₹42,367 crore while profit (after tax) climbed 21.8% to ₹31,961 crore. The board of Tata Sons has recommended a final dividend of ₹1,10,717 per share.

Cipla gets U.S. FDA nod for generic of asthma, COPD drug

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Cipla has received approval from the U.S. Food and Drug Administration (U.S. FDA) for its abbreviated new drug application (AN-DA) for generic Advair Diskus (fluticasone propionate and salmeterol inhalation powder) in three strengths – 100/50 mcg, 250/50 mcg, and 500/50 mcg. This approval represents Cipla's first dry powder inhaler (DPI) approval from its U.S.-based manufacturing network. The product is expected to be launched in the second quarter (Q2) of FY27 in the U.S., the company said on Monday.



The U.S. Food and Drug Administration headquarters in White Oak, Maryland. REUTERS

The product is a therapeutically equivalent version of Advair Diskus, a widely prescribed combination therapy indicated for the treatment of asthma and chronic obstructive pulmonary disease (COPD). Citing IQVIA numbers, Cipla said the U.S.

market for fluticasone propionate and salmeterol inhalation powder is approximately \$908 million. “This approval marks our first dry powder inhaler from our New York facility and reflects our targeted investments in building differentiated inhalation manufacturing capabilities in the U.S,” CEO-Cipla North America Marc Falkin said. MD and Global CEO Achin Gupta said the approval reinforces Cipla's commitment to expanding access to complex therapies in the U.S. and highlights its strength in developing and scaling sophisticated inhalation products through integrated capabilities.”

Alembic's constipation drug receives U.S. FDA nod

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Alembic Pharmaceuticals has received final approval from the U.S. FDA for its abbreviated new drug application for Prucalopride Tablets, 1 mg and 2 mg, used to treat chronic idiopathic constipation (CIC). The approved ANDA is therapeutically equivalent to Takeda Pharmaceuticals USA Inc.'s reference-listed drug, Motegrity Tablets (1 mg and 2 mg), the company said on Tuesday. Prucalopride Tablets had an estimated U.S. market size of \$100 million for the 12 months ended March 2026, Alembic said.

Family-owned firms have big appetites for U.S. snack M&A



Weathering the storm: Kellogg's Raisin Bran and Corn Flakes cereal displayed at a grocery store. REUTERS

Reuters
NEW YORK

Family-owned food companies are stocking up on U.S. snack companies, which are warming to the idea of private backers - many of them overseas - that can help them weather the storm in the supermarket aisles. Last week, Hanover, Pennsylvania-based potato chip maker Utzagreed to be taken private by Germany's Intersnack Group along with Utz's founding families.

The nearly \$3 billion transaction marks the first U.S. deal for Intersnack, a subsidiary of family-owned food conglomerate Pfeifer & Langen. That follows two deals by Italy's family-owned Ferrero, which bought both cereal maker WK Kellogg and U.S. protein snack brand Power Crunch. Also last year, Mars, the Virginia-based maker of M&M's and Snickers, which is controlled by the Mars family, bought Pringles and Cheez-It maker Kellanova in a blockbuster \$36 billion take-private deal.

Snapping up firms
Families that have invested in the snack business for decades, some for more than a century, are snapping up public companies they see as undervalued following selloffs based on investors' concerns about the growing popularity of weight-loss drugs, changing consumer tastes and stubbornly high inflation.

"They want exposure to the U.S. market, and believe there's some public market value dislocation, which in turn is being used as a buying opportunity," said Adam Taetle, Lazard's global head of consumer and retail investment banking.

Some food companies such as Campbell's and Lamb Weston fell out of the S&P 500 this year because their market capitalisations shrunk too much to remain in the index.

The elephant in snack aisle
For public snack companies that have become takeover targets, family-owned buyers are viewed as more patient long-term owners than private equity firms, which find it harder to justify such purchases, particularly because of limited ways to exit the investment later, sources said.

Some private equity firms and public companies are also cautious of making a big play in the salty snacks category because of the competition it sets up against Frito-Lay owner PepsiCo, sources said. PepsiCo's last food acquisition was a \$1.2 billion deal for tortilla chip brand Siete Foods in2025.

For public acquirers, it's harder to defend a big snack acquisition if it falters. J.M. Smucker bought Twinkies maker Hostess in 2023 for \$5.6 billion. It has recorded \$2.9 billion in impairment charges since then, and shares are down 18% since the deal.

"This is the fourth time in the past two years that a private company outside our radar has swooped in to acquire a public food company," a TD Cowen report on the Utz deal said. "Quite possibly, this could help the market set a valuation floor for other 'fallen stars' in SMID-cap food and beverage." The acquisition valued Utz at roughly 12 times core earnings,which excludes interest, taxes, depreciation and amortisation. TD cited BellRing Brands, which trades below eight times next year's EBITDA, and Simply Good Foods, which trades below six times that figure, as potential targets. PepsiCo trades at around 12 times EBITDA.

Mergers across borders
Many of the recent deals have a cross-border component, as these companies look to globalize their brands the way Kellanova did with Pringles before Mars bought it. The same thinking influenced Maryland-based spice maker McCormick's decision to buy Unilever's food unit earlier this year.

Intersnack, which makes Tyrells, Pom-Bear and Hula Hoops crisps, is little known in the U.S., but is seeking to become a leading global player in salty snacks and better compete with PepsiCo. The company, founded in 1968 in Germany, now operates in 31 countries. It generated \$5 billion of sales in 2025, which could grow to \$6.6 billion when combined with Utz.

"We see a tremendous opportunity to partner and build onUtz's strong foundation and help shape the future of snacking inNorth America," Intersnack's executive chairman Johan van Winkelsaid in the deal announcement.

'China starts making home-grown immersion DUV chipmaking tools'

DUV effort led by Shanghai's Aishengna, which absorbed teams from top Chinese lithography startups; Western curbs may drive adoption of local tools if foreign servicing tightens; Aishengna was established in August 2023 with registered capital of 7 billion yuan (\$1.0 billion)

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
SINGAPORE

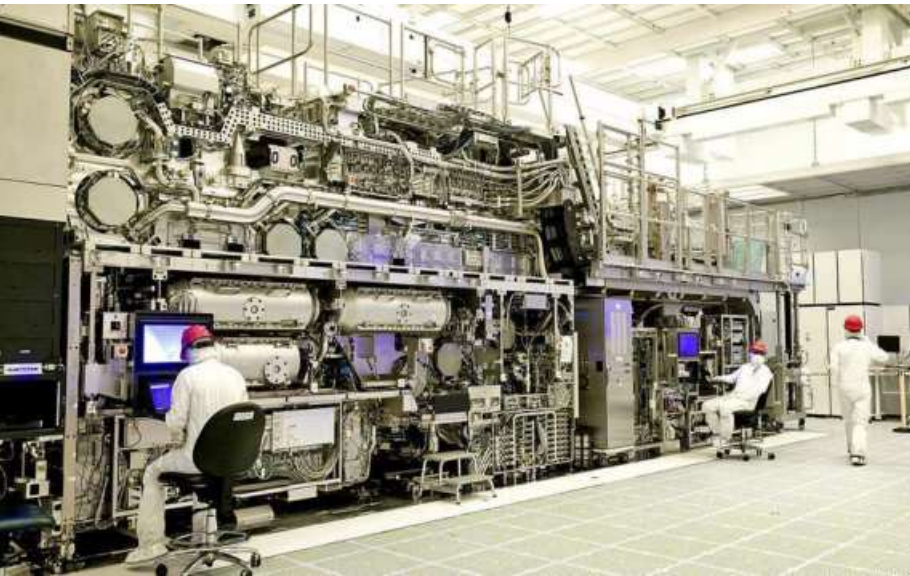
China has begun mass producing domestically developed immersion deep-ultraviolet (DUV) lithography machines, a technology crucial to advanced chip-making, a person familiar with the matter said, marking a key step forward in Beijing's drive to reduce its reliance on foreign technologies.

Shanghai Aishengna Electronic Technology Group, a little-known Chinese state-owned company, is leading the production effort after incorporating teams from top Chinese lithography startups, the source said, declining to be named due to the sensitivity of the subject.

Self-sufficiency boost
The development represents a win for Beijing's nationwide semiconductor self-sufficiency initiative, one of President Xi Jinping's highest priorities, but will not pose an immediate commercial threat for Dutch supplier ASML.

DUV is a key chipmaking tool long dominated by ASML.

The Information, a tech industry news outlet, first reported on China's development of the tool on



Chip play: Workers at "High NA EUV" lithography system at an Intel facility in U.S. REUTERS

Monday, noting that an unidentified state-backed company in Shanghai had begun manufacturing the machines and planned to produce about five this year and roughly 20 in 2027. Reuters is the first to report the identity of the company.

Needs more testing
Aishengna's DUV machine is expected to need further testing and remains far from matching the Dutch firm's competing models, the source said.

Successful deployment would, however, give Chinese chipmakers an alternative source of equipment if Western governments further restrict exports or servicing of foreign lithography tools.

Even as Beijing pushes for self-sufficiency, China remains a crucial revenue pillar for ASML, accounting for roughly 16% of the Dutch giant's net sales in the first half of the year

The Chinese-made DUV machines are expected to be delivered this year to leading Chinese chipmakers including Semiconductor Manufacturing International Corp (SMIC), Hua Hong Semiconductor and memory-chip maker ChangXin Memory Technologies (CXMT), the Information said, citing two people familiar with the

matter. Immersion DUV machines use a layer of water between the projection lens and a silicon wafer to print smaller circuit patterns than conventional dry systems.

Advanced chips
They are used to produce a broad range of chips and can also be pushed to manufacture more advanced semiconductors through multiple patterning, which requires repeated exposures of the same layer.

ASML did not immediately respond to a request for comment. SMIC, Hua Hong and CXMT also did not respond to requests for comment.

After dropping 8% on the report by The Information on Monday, ASML

Mine closure opens opportunities in circular economy but requires coordinated efforts

Santosh V. Perumal



Huge potential: India has as many as 341 closed/abandoned coal mines as on March 31, 2024. REUTERS

The ₹40,000-crore mine closure corpus, which the Union government has earmarked, signals the beginning of a new economic lifecycle, wherein future generations inherit thriving ecosystems.

Abandoning an ecologically-insensitive 'extract-and-abandon' model, India, the second largest global producer of coal, has chosen a path of circular economy, implying diversified local economies; even as details are sketchy on the breakup of corpus' deployment though the Centre officially announced 25% allocation for community development.

The closure— a planned, people-centric process or PPP plans to unlock a new, green services industry; improve environmental, social and governance (ESG) performance; convert exhausted mines into productive and tourism assets; support India's voluntary carbon market (VCM); help local micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs) and rural enterprises and generate rural green employment.

This scientific approach, evolving from a regulatory obligation into a national mission of ecological regeneration and sustainable development, derives strength from 2025 Mine Closure Guidelines, mandating progressive closure, financial assurance via escrow accounts, independent monitoring and post-closure environmental surveillance. The past two years has seen 42 mines closed with the Ministry of Coal eyeing scientifically closing over 105 mines in the coming years.

Scientific mine closure

is systematic restoring of a mine to safe, environmentally-sustainable and economically productive condition after mineral extraction ends.

Beginning with technical stabilisation, ensuring long-term physical safety for nearby communities, the process then goes through the stage of environmental restoration. It includes social and economic rehabilitation.

The Coal Controller Organisation— the technical and institutional backbone of new mine closure system— has designed RECLAIM, L.I.V.E.S., SUVIKALP and SUVIKALP Samvaad, targeting local communities, mine planners, mine policy makers and operators respectively.

The recent initiative also saw an implementation pact between the Ministry of Coal and Deutsche Gesellschaft für Internationale Zusammenarbeit (GIZ) of Germany for technical cooperation on 'To-be closed mines' aiming at strengthening ties in scientific mine closure, mine repurposing, technical capacity building and knowledge exchange.

The distinguishing feature of scientific closure is the productive reuse of re-

claimed land as PPP transforms degraded land into long-term economic assets. "Time has come to change the phrase from mine closure to mine of wealth," Jitendra Singh, Minister of State (Independent Charge) for Science and Technology, put it.

The details of corpus allocation have not been stated but but experiences suggest a bulk of it may go towards environmental reclamation followed by community development, mine repurposing, safety and monitoring.

Bright spots
This sustainable and circular mining framework, balancing mineral development with ecological conservation and community welfare, seeks to strengthen rural economies as it allocates 25% of approved closure costs — about ₹10,000 crore over the coming decade — for community development, including livelihood creation, public infrastructure and skill development. This helps mining districts reduce their dependence on coal extraction.

Catalysing a new mine restoration economy, the initiative is slated to see major growth sectors as re-

newable energy, digital mining technologies (MiningTech), carbon finance, environmental consulting and ESG advisory, geospatial technology, green infrastructure and sustainable construction and ecological restoration.

Mine closure is evolving into a climate-finance opportunity for India, whose economy-wide net-zero target is set for 2070 and comes amid India's VCM moving beyond the conceptual stage to a formal regulatory framework with dedicated institutions and a sovereign-backed offset mechanism.

Global turnaround
Global experiences show post-mining land transformation can turn them into engines of sustainable tourism, employment and regional development.

The U.K Eden Project, a former China clay pit, is now a Botanical Garden; Poland's Wieliczka Salt Mine turned into UNESCO World Heritage underground tourism; Germany's Zeche Zollverein transformed Ruhr coal belt into a cultural economy; Romanian Salina Turda, a salt mine turned underground amusement park; and the U.K. Big Pit National Coal Museum; all have reported increasing footfall and revenue.

India is several decades behind the U.K., Germany and Poland in monetising closed mines via tourism.

Lessons from U.S. Appalachian projects (carbon removals) suggest for India, integrating mine closure with robust carbon accounting could unlock a new asset class.

Global investors increasingly evaluate local mining companies on ESG param-

eters, which become particularly important as they seek global financing.

Reality bites
India had as many as 341 closed/abandoned coal mines as on March 31, 2024, Ministry of Coal had said in the Lok Sabha.

However, numbers tell a sorry tale as India has only a few operational examples where former mines have been turned into tourism hubs— Zawar Mines Heritage Tourism Project, Rajasthan; Sandur Eco-Tourism and Kudremukh Iron Ore Region, Karnataka; Neyveli Lignite Mine View Point, Tamil Nadu; and Indian Bureau of Mines' demonstration projects are among the few.

India has not yet commercialised reclaimed mines at scale as most projects stay CSR or corporate social responsibility initiatives or under pilot basis, or as local sites. Consequently, there is a dearth of national database on annual tourist arrivals or revenue from them.

If scientifically reclaimed, several closed mines could be repurposed into eco-tourism, adventure tourism, concert venues, water-based theme parks and underground tourism, whose multiplier effect on the local economies is huge.

For India, where many depend on mining, the multiplier effect will depend on what replaces the closed mines.

The Coal Neer packaged drinking water at Handihua underground mine in Orissa is just the beginning. The Centre's latest move is expected to create opportunities across industries.

The scientific closure

appears smooth but due to multi-stakeholders nature, it is challenged multi-directionally. Multiple agencies — including the Ministries of Mines, Coal, Environment, Forest and Climate Change, State governments and pollution control boards— make the entire process tedious. Coordination deficit can delay approvals and weaken oversight. Several old mines were abandoned before modern norms came into force and many lack responsible operators or adequate financial provisions (as no mine closure plans existed for the mines discontinued/abandoned/ closed before 2009).

In a mine closure plan, states face shortages of skilled personnel, environmental auditors and monitoring infrastructure.

Much of the corpus, built via statutory financial assurance and leaseholders' mine closure deposits, is ring-fenced from individual mining leases and is meant to finance closure obligations of specific ones and not a common pool.

Need of the hour
Scientifically closing mines will need an artistic maneuvering of multi-level potholes, eschewing the risks of greenwashing. The corpus alone cannot guarantee success as stakeholders in the value chain must guard against the pitfalls of weak monitoring, fund diversion or underutilisation and inflated compliance claims.

Closure plans should be independently audited supported by real-time digital monitoring using drones and satellite imagery and backed by strict post-closure environmental surveillance.

‘We are not anyone’s proxy force’: Iranian Kurdish party

Spokesperson of the Kurdistan Free Life Party says the group aims to build a democratic, self-administered society rather than engaging in traditional armed struggle; adds it will join the U.S.-Iran-Israel war only if the ‘existence of the Kurdish people comes under threat’ and that it supports pressure against the Islamic Republic’s ‘repressive domestic and expansionist policies’ as long as civilians are safe

INTERVIEW
Rivar Abdanan

Stanly Johny

The Kurdistan Free Life Party (PJAK), an armed militant group and political party based in Iran’s Kurdish region (also known as Eastern Kurdistan), says they are not a proxy of any power but a force for democratic change and freedom in Iran. PJAK, which is aligned with the Kurdistan Workers Party (PKK) of Türkiye, has sought greater autonomy for Eastern Kurdistan. After the U.S. and Israel launched their war on Iran on February 28, there were speculations that Kurdish groups in Iran would join the war against the Islamic Republic.

In an email interview with *The Hindu*, Rivar Abdanan, a spokesperson of PJAK and a member of the party’s Leadership Council, said PJAK would enter the war only if the “existence of the Kurdish people comes under threat”. He, however, added that the primary cause of the current conflict lies in the Islamic Republic’s “repressive domestic policies and its expansionist policies across the region”. Asked if PJAK would condemn the U.S.-Israel’s war on Iran, Mr. Abdanan said the issue cannot be reduced to “a simple choice between encouraging war or con-

demning war”. Edited excerpts:

PJAK and the broader Kurdish coalition have emphasised certain restraint or an independent course during the war. What factors are guiding PJAK’s current military posture?

Whenever the attacks of the Islamic Republic reach a level that threatens the existence of the Kurdish people, we will certainly respond. In the past, whenever the regime attacked the Kurdish people or PJAK forces, we responded within the framework of the internationally recognised principle of legitimate self-defence.

PJAK is a political party. We seek to operate within the framework of democratic politics. We are not a traditional armed movement whose activities are defined solely by armed struggle. The Islamic Republic wants to drag us into a long and exhausting war. Our objective, however, is to preserve the Kurdish people’s social and political potential for democratic struggle so that they can play their role when the right opportunity arises.

We are not anyone’s proxy force. We strongly reject the mindset that views the Kurds merely as a military force. The Kurds are a nation struggling for freedom and democracy. As long as the political future of the Kurdish people

has not been clearly defined in the plans of the world’s major powers, and until we are certain that the Kurds will not once again become victims and will enjoy a political status worthy of their rights, we will not become part of any international coalition or project. However, if we see a policy that genuinely serves the interests of the Kurdish people, we will shape our own policies toward constructive engagement with governments and actors working against the Islamic Republic.

Do you condemn the American-Israeli attacks on Iran?

We do not believe the issue can be reduced to a simple choice between encouraging war or condemning war. PJAK does not pursue a policy of militarism, nor do we consider war an appropriate path to achieving freedom and democracy. At the same time, we believe the primary cause of the current conflict lies in the Islamic Republic’s repressive domestic policies and its expansionist policies across the region. This regime bears responsibility for the blood of thousands of Kurdish and Iranian citizens. It has repeatedly attacked our forces and continues to use severe violence against the Kurdish people.

During last winter’s nationwide uprising against the regime, thousands of Kurds in Ilam and Ker-



RIVAR ABDANAN

mashan – both integral parts of Kurdistan – were massacred. Therefore, we consider pressure on this dictatorial regime and strikes against its centres of repression to be positive, as long as they do not harm civilians or undermine the future right to self-determination of the peoples of Iran, including the Kurds.

How do you look at your relations with Israel and the U.S.?

PJAK struggles on the basis of the interests of the Kurdish nation and for the achievement of a democratic political status for the Kurds in Iran. For this reason, we keep our diplomatic channels open to all governments and political actors whose engagement could serve Kurdish interests and support the establishment of a democratic political system in Iran. Our only red line in relations with states and political forces is the protection of our people’s national in-

terests. Any relationship that does not undermine Kurdish national interests and contributes to the expansion of freedom and democracy in Iran is, in our view, legitimate.

There have been discussions about Kurdish groups potentially playing a larger ground role or joining efforts against the Iranian state. Under what conditions would PJAK consider more active participation in the conflict?

If the current war and crisis reach a point where we believe the existence of the Kurdish people is under threat, and it becomes clear that our intervention is necessary to protect them, we will certainly make the decisions required by the situation.

At the same time, we believe that the Kurdish community in Iran has achieved a level of self-organisation that enables it,

even under difficult circumstances, to protect its existence while continuing its democratic struggle for freedom.

PJAK is part of the Coalition of Political Forces of Iranian Kurdistan. How is coordination working within the coalition amid the war?

As PJAK, we strive to work in close coordination and cooperation with other Kurdish parties within the framework of the Coalition of Political Forces of Iranian Kurdistan. So far, this cooperation, coordination, and convergence have been positive and constructive.

For many years, Türkiye pursued its anti-Kurdish policies with all the means at its disposal. However, for some time now, a process of dialogue and efforts to find a political and democratic solution to the Kurdish question has begun. If this process continues, it could also encourage a more positive perception of Türkiye among the Kurds of Iran.

However, if these negotiations collapse, or if Türkiye follows through on its threats to intervene against the Kurds of Iran during the Iran-U.S.-Israel conflict, the region will face a new and serious crisis.

As for Iraq, as long as its policies remain under the influence of the Islamic Republic or are shaped by Türkiye’s direction, it can-

not exercise genuine political independence.

There are also deep concerns within Kurdish society regarding the policies of the U.S. and Israel toward the Kurds. America’s inconsistent approach in Rojava and toward the Syrian Kurds has also created concern among the Kurds of Iran. Likewise, the capture of the Kurdish leader Abdullah Ocalan and his transfer to Türkiye – with Israel’s cooperation – remains deeply embedded in the collective memory of the Kurdish people.

What does PJAK envision for Iranian Kurdistan especially considering that Iran is under attack?

The Kurdish people possess significant political, intellectual, and defensive capacities. Their ability to influence geopolitical developments in both Iran and the wider region is considerable. In my view, the Kurds can continue their democratic struggle alongside the other peoples of Iran and play an important role in the country’s transition beyond the current regime.

During the ‘Woman, Life, Freedom’ (*Jin, Jiyan, Azadi*) uprising in 2022-23, we witnessed how PJAK’s political vision and the Kurdish philosophy of struggle inspired people across Iran. I believe that if we continue our struggle within the framework of the ‘Woman, Life, Free-

dom’ movement, the Kurdish people can achieve freedom while, within a democratic republic of Iran, exercising their right to self-determination through a system of democratic self-administration.

How do you look at Iran’s attacks on the Kurdistan region of Iraq? Is it part of any larger Iranian plan to weaken the Kurdish resistance?

The Islamic Republic, like the Pahlavi regime before it, has always viewed the Kurdish people through a security lens. The suppression of the Kurds has become one of the fundamental pillars of its state policy. The very existence of the Kurdistan Region’s political system does not pose a threat to Iran.

The Islamic Republic justifies its attacks on the Kurdistan Region by claiming that Iranian Kurdish parties use the region as a base to enter Iran. In reality, this is nothing more than a pretext. The regime accepts the Kurds only as long as they do not struggle for their freedom. The moment the Kurdish people speak of their rights or take action to defend them, the Islamic Republic responds with a highly securitised and violent approach.

As PJAK, we will continue to resist the regime’s attacks against the Kurdish people and their movement for freedom.

UN chief makes rare Cyprus visit to help ease decades-old ethnic division

Associated Press
NICOSIA

U.N. Secretary-General Antonio Guterres on a rare visit to Cyprus said on Tuesday he was demonstrating his commitment to resolving the island nation’s decades-old ethnic division, even as expectations remain low for a speedy breakthrough leading to a peace accord.

“I will do everything I can to support the Greek Cypriots and Turkish Cypriots in this very important moment,” Mr. Guterres said after talks with Greek Cypriot President Nikos Christodoulides.

The U.N. chief also met with Turkish Cypriot leader Tufan Erhürman and was scheduled to hold joint meetings with both la-



Peace moves: UN Secretary-General Antonio Guterres in a meeting with Cyprus President Nikos Christodoulides on Tuesday. REUTERS

ter in the day and on Wednesday.

The first visit by a U.N. chief in 16 years came during renewed efforts to resume formal peace talks after a nearly decade-long hiatus. The last major push, which Mr. Guterres mediated in 2017, col-

lapsed in recriminations over who and what was to blame for the impasse.

Numerous rounds of U.N.-mediated talks have shared the same fate since 1974, when the island was divided following a Turkish invasion prompted by an Athens-backed coup with

the stated goal of union with Greece. Turkish Cypriots declared independence in the island’s northern third in 1983 but it is only recognised by Türkiye, which maintains more than 35,000 troops there. Cyprus joined the European Union in 2004, but only the internationally recognised south enjoys full benefits.

A few months before his U.N. term expires, Mr. Guterres wants to convene a wider meeting to involve top diplomats from Cyprus’ guarantors – Greece, Türkiye and Britain – to declare a formal start to peace talks. It is hoped a declaration would offer momentum to the process so that Mr. Guterres’ successor could see it through.

Sacred march



Twilight devotion: The sun rises as Shia pilgrims march towards Karbala, to observe Arbæen that marks the end of a 40-day mourning period following the Day of Ashura, in Najaf, Iraq, on Tuesday. AP

Seoul uses AI-powered cameras to detect suicide risk and help save lives

Agence France-Presse
SEOUL

When AI-powered cameras on bridges over Seoul’s Han River raise the alarm that someone may be about to jump, acting quickly is vital. The waterway is a landmark of the glittering South Korean capital, but also a frequent scene of despair in a country with one of the world’s highest suicide rates.

The artificial intelligence-driven surveillance system alerts first responders if someone lingers in certain locations, enters an area deemed unsafe or picks up one of the bridges’ dedicated suicide-prevention phones.

It has been strikingly effective, said Kim Jun-young, chief of the Hangang Bridge CCTV Integrated Control Centre, with the

rescue rate over the river rising to more than 99% from 56% in 2012.

Emergency crews can reach most bridges within five minutes – the critical window to intervene and save a life, he said. “We see our role as giving them one more chance to think it over, because it may not be the decision you want”.

From a height of about 30 metres, striking the water is akin to crashing a car at 60 kilometres per hour, he said.

Persuading people who have made up their minds is not easy, Mr. Kim said, as they often struggle with rescuers or sprint away “as if running a 100-metre race”.

Others can make a final, split-second decision when they hear approaching sirens, before help arrives.

Last year, nearly 900

cameras on 17 bridges identified more than 1,200 incidents, he said, but “about eight people” could not be saved.

Broader crisis

The Han River AI system has been operating since 2021, but South Korea remains gripped by a broader suicide crisis called “a disgrace on the world stage” by President Lee Jae Myung. The suicide rate in 2024 climbed above 29 deaths per 100,000 people, the highest since 2011. It is the leading cause of death among people aged 10 to 49, government figures show.

Relentless academic pressure, heavy workloads and a culture that holds individuals responsible for failure can leave people ill-equipped to cope with life’s setbacks or seek help,



Vital cues: Kim Jun-young of Hangang Bridge CCTV Integrated Control Centre explains how the system alerts first responders. AFP

said Yoo Jae-hyun, director of suicide prevention at Seoul St. Mary’s Hospital.

Many who have tried to end their lives told him “they feel they have become a burden to those around them, and that everyone else would be better off if they were gone”, Mr. Yoo said.

Koreans in their twen-

ties account for the largest share of people treated in emergency rooms after suicide attempts, according to Mr. Yoo.

33-year-old cartoonist Smiling Stone Hwang now lives what she describes as a resilient life, after she was saved by first responders. After losing her father to suicide in 2014, Ms.

Hwang inherited his debts and endured years of lawsuits and asset seizures – leaving her unable to hold a bank account in her own name. Throughout her 20s, she juggled multiple cash-paying jobs, often working gruelling hours.

Suicide “didn’t feel like a particularly tragic choice. It felt like a rational one”, Ms. Hwang said.

‘Blink of an eye’

Many CCTV systems worldwide use some form of AI to help spot danger.

Japanese company Asila says its AI surveillance system can detect unusual behaviour, such as falls, or someone who might be preparing to jump from a height.

Its AI tool has been learning behaviour patterns from cameras in public facilities such as shop-

ping centres and stations.

In two separate incidents, it alerted guards to men standing on rooftops who were able to be talked down, chief product officer Yuka Suzuki said.

It is not meant to replace humans and cannot bring down Japan’s suicide rate – the highest in the G7 – alone, she stressed.

“It’s still often difficult to provide proper mental health support,” Ms. Suzuki said. But it is significant “if we can reduce the number of incidents, even by a little, where people lose their lives in the blink of an eye”.

In Seoul, CCTV Control Centre’s Kim recalled one case in which a young man was intercepted by the AI system and rescue workers, only to return later that day and suddenly make another attempt

while smoking with a friend.

Despite rescuers and a boat already being on the water, they were unable to save him.

Cartoonist Hwang’s late father, who had long struggled with alcohol addiction, was once a successful film producer. Shortly before his death, he visited Ms. Hwang at the cafe where she worked, according to her cartoon-based memoir, “I Am a Suicide Loss Survivor”.

He brought her a gift, but the usually empty cafe was packed, and she never got to buy him a coffee. For a time after his death, Ms. Hwang returned daily to leave a cup of coffee “at the cramped table where he never got to sit”.

(If you are in distress, please reach out on the helpline Tele MANAS at 14416)

COMMANDING SHOW

Jadumani storms into semifinals, ensures India another medal



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Jadumani Singh stormed into the semifinals of the men's 55kg boxing event with a commanding 5-0 victory over Zambia's Mwengo Mwale at the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow on Tuesday. The Indian, who looked fluent throughout the bout, is assured of at least a bronze medal.

MIXED BAG

Vishal qualifies for the 400m semifinal even as Rajesh bows out



X@MEDIA_SAI

National record holder Vishal T.K. (46.49s) kept India's medal hopes alive in the men's 400m after qualifying for the semifinals, while compatriot Rajesh Ramesh (47.43s) narrowly missed the cut in the athletics competition at the Commonwealth Games on Tuesday. The 22-year-old Vishal finished second in Round 1 Heat 6.

MOVING ON

Ten Doeschate departs from India's coaching staff



FILE PHOTO: R. RAGU

Ryan ten Doeschate has stepped down as India's assistant coach, bringing an end to a stint with the team that began alongside Gautam Gambhir's appointment as head coach in July 2024. The Dutchman is understood to have tendered his resignation following the conclusion of India's recent tour of England — **Amol Karhadkar**.

ALMOST THERE

West Indies one wicket away from winning the opening Test



AFP

West Indies was one wicket away from beating Pakistan when tea was called on the fourth day of the opening Test in Tarouba on Tuesday. **The scores:** West Indies 311 & 181 in 54.5 overs (Mohammad Abbas 5/22) vs Pakistan 282 & 114/9 in 39 overs (Babar Azam 53 batting, Jayden Seales 4/20) **at tea**.



Ending a drought: Sharmila and Shilpa ended a 20-year wait for a CWG para athletics medal. PTI

Sharmila claims gold in para shot put F57

C'WEALTH GAMES

Press Trust of India
GLASGOW

Sharmila Dhankar scripted history on Monday as she won India's first para athletics gold medal in the Commonwealth Games, clinching the top spot in the women's shot put F57 event here.

The 40-year-old produced a season-best throw of 9.81m to end India's 20-year wait for a para athletics medal in the CWG.

Another Indian, Shilpa Shyla, was awarded the bronze medal following an Indian protest in controversial circumstances. Shyla had produced a personal best effort of 7.26m.

Nigeria's Eucharía Iyiazi was initially placed at the bronze medal position but after a protest and official review, her only valid mark was adjudged a foul. That led to Shyla being upgraded to bronze from initial

fourth place. However, it is likely that a counter protest may also be launched by Nigeria.

F57 classification is for athletes with lower limb impairments, limb deficiencies, or reduced muscle power.

Infected with polio on her left leg at the age of two, Sharmila won a gold medal in the Fazza International Para Athletics Championship this year. She also took part in the 2022 Birmingham Games and finished fourth.

Meanwhile, India's Srihari Nataraj qualified for the 100m backstroke semifinals but veteran Sanjay Prakash failed to go past the Heats of 50m butterfly event on Tuesday. Srihari finished fifth in his Heat and 13th overall with a timing of 55.58 seconds. The 16 fastest swimmers advanced to the semifinals. Sajan, however, failed to qualify after finishing eighth in his Heat and 28th overall.

Kushare clinches a historic silver for India in high jump

The 31-year-old is the first from the country to finish second in the discipline at the Games; Jamaica's Beckford takes home the gold; injuries dash the hopes of Tejaswin and hurdler Shirse

K. Keerthivasan
GLASGOW

For every attempt by Sarvesh Kushare in the men's high jump final of the Commonwealth Games at the Scotstoun Stadium here on Monday, the modest gathering of spectators responded with warm applause and cheers. But when the Indian stepped up for his third and final attempt at 2.28m in expectations of a gold medal — after Romaine Beckford had failed to clear the same height in his final attempt — sepulchral silence descended over the stadium. It was evident that the crowd wanted the 31-year-old Indian to win.

However, it wasn't to be. Kushare settled for the silver medal — the first for India in able-bodied athletics at this Games. It was also the first silver by an Indian high jumper at the quadrennial event.

Beckford had sailed past 2.25m in his first try, while the Indian National record holder managed the same height only in his third, handing the Jamaican the gold on countback.

"I am happy to win a medal in my second Commonwealth Games. The cold weather affected my warm-up and warm-down routine. I was a bit con-



No time to relax: Kushare said he will now focus on the Asian Games. AFP

fused, but it was a good learning experience and a lot of fun. I won't relax now and will focus on the Asian Games," said Kushare.

However, it turned out to be a disappointing day for Tejaswin Sankar, the bronze medalist at the 2022 Birmingham Commonwealth Games.

Initially, there was confusion when the official Commonwealth Games website displayed a DNS (Did Not Start) against his name.

When queried, officials said it was a "technical glitch". A few minutes later, spectators saw Tejaswin on the stadium's giant screen

waving at them.

The 27-year-old failed in his opening attempt at 2.05m before retiring from the competition.

Later, Tejaswin said he withdrew because of severe pain caused by tendonitis in his knee.

"I think I've always had tendonitis in my knee. There isn't a high jumper in the world who hasn't suffered tendonitis. It was just one of those days. I was confident of doing well and winning a medal. In fact, I was feeling good and was in great shape during my warm-up," he said while trying to control his tears.

Tejaswin said he would now focus on recovering in time for his next event, the decathlon on Friday.

"I'll try to fix this injury. I'm not on vacation. There are two days before my next event, and I'll start my recovery," he said.

Jack Kimani of England finished third (2.2m), while the third Indian in the field, Adarsh Ram, came fifth (2.15).

Meanwhile, Tejas Shirse finished eighth and last in the men's 110m hurdles final in 15.39 seconds and was seen limping towards the end of the race.

"I felt pain in my left ankle during the warm-up before the race," Shirse said.

Ajaya wins silver, does one better than dad

K. Keerthivasan
GLASGOW

Ajaya Babu grew up accompanying his father, Valuri Srinivasa Rao, to weightlifting competitions, learning the finer aspects of the sport from him. Inspired by Rao, who won a bronze medal in the men's 56kg category at the 2010 Commonwealth Games in New Delhi, Ajaya arrived in Glasgow for his debut

Games determined to make his dad proud.

He did exactly that, although he was left disappointed after missing the gold by a whisker in the men's 79kg event at the Scottish Event Campus here on Monday night.

The 21-year-old from Kondavelagada village in Andhra Pradesh's Vizianagaram district finished with the silver.

He managed a total lift

of 330kg, just 1kg behind Malaysia's Muhammad Erry Hidayat, who created Games records in clean and jerk (184) and total (331). Ajaya, too, produced a Games record of 149 in snatch while Hidayat managed 147. Ajaya lifted 181 in clean and jerk.

"I should have done better. I dedicate the medal to Indian Weightlifting Federation, coaches, support staff and my father. I fol-

lowed the sport after seeing my father who has been my inspiration. I wanted to win gold but couldn't. I will try to win it next time," Ajaya said.

Nirupama Devi failed to clear 123kg on all three clean and jerk attempts, resulting in a no-mark in the section and a DNF in the women's 63kg final. She was placed fifth after snatch with a best lift of 93kg.



Fine show: Ajaya produced a Games record of 149kg in snatch. GETTY IMAGES

Indian women edge past Australia, book semifinal spot

C'WEALTH TT

Amol Karhadkar
NEW DELHI

India overcame a spirited Australia to begin the second stage of the women's team event at the 22nd Commonwealth Table Tennis Championships with a hard-fought victory at the Thyagaraja Sports Complex on Tuesday.

The evening session marked the start of the second stage — effectively the Super Eight — and Australia ensured the top seed was made to work for every



Minor scare: Manav being treated by doctors after hurting his forehead during the match against Australia. AMOL KARHADKAR

point. Yangzi Liu, the highest-ranked Australian singles player, was the standout performer, racing past both Yashaswini Ghorpade and Sreeja Akula without dropping a game.

Yashaswini, however, bounced back admirably. Showing remarkable composure after her opening defeat, the youngster outlasted the experienced Min Hyung Jee in the deciding

rubber to confirm India's entry into the semifinals.

The Indian women had eased past Sri Lanka 3-0 earlier in the afternoon.

The defining performance of the tie, though, came from Olympian Sutirtha Mukherjee.

Locked in a tense battle against Constantina Psihogios in the third singles, Sutirtha relied on her experience and timely winners to edge a gripping five-game contest. She clinched the decider 13-11.

Sreeja lost to Liu as Australia made it 2-2 before Yashaswini sealed the tie.

The Indian men, mean-

while, enjoyed a more comfortable outing against Australia. World No. 38 Manav Thakkar shrugged off a cut on his forehead — sustained after colliding with the umpire's desk during the second game — to complete his singles victory as India sealed the tie 3-0.

G. Sathiyar has withdrawn from the men's singles competition.

Sathiyar confirmed to *The Hindu* that he will, however, compete in the men's doubles alongside Harmeet Desai and in the mixed doubles with Sreeja. "Both these events will serve as preparation for the

Asian Games," he said.

Top results: Second stage: Women: India bt Australia 3-2 (Yashaswini Ghorpade lost to Yangzi Liu 13-15, 9-11, 5-11; Sreeja Akula bt Min Hyung Jee 12-10, 7-11, 11-5, 11-9; Sutirtha Mukherjee bt Constantina Psihogios 11-8, 9-11, 8-11, 11-8, 13-11; Yangzi bt Sreeja 11-8, 11-5, 11-5; Yashaswini bt Min 11-5, 11-9, 11-8); India bt Sri Lanka 3-0; Canada bt Sri Lanka 3-0; Australia bt Canada 3-0.

Men: India bt Australia 3-0 (Manush Shah bt Nicholas Lum 11-7, 9-11, 12-10, 11-13, 11-3; Manav Thakkar bt Chulong Nie 11-7, 11-6, 11-4; G. Sathiyar bt Aditya Sareen 11-8, 11-8, 11-8); Malaysia bt Maldives 3-1; Sri Lanka bt Namibia 3-0.

Jadeja is back

After being rested for the one-off Test against Afghanistan in New Chandigarh in June, Ravindra Jadeja has made a return. The 37-year-old all-rounder is one of four spinners at Shubman Gill's disposal, along with Saransh, Manav Suthar and Kuldeep Yadav. Manav had thoroughly impressed with a match haul of seven for 62 on debut versus Afghanistan.

Jasprit Bumrah has also returned to spearhead the pace attack, but his selec-



Saransh. FILE PHOTO: K. MURALI KUMAR

Off-spinner Saransh Jain has earned a maiden call-up to India's Test squad for a two-match series against Sri Lanka next month. The two Tests will be played in Galle (August 15-19) and Colombo (August 23-27). In preparation for the series, the Indian team will play a four-day practice match in Colombo from August 7.

Saransh's opportunity comes on the back of off-spinning all-rounder Washington Sundar sustaining a hamstring injury during the ODI series against England. The BCCI stated that Washington wasn't available for the first Test, and hence has been left out altogether.

Saransh, who plays for Madhya Pradesh in domestic cricket, has picked up 188 scalps in 54 First Class appearances. The 33-year-old bats left-handed, and can contribute lower down the order. He has been part of the India-A set-up since February 2024.

tion is subject to fitness. He missed the last ODI on the tour of England after sustaining an injury to his left knee. Mohammed Siraj, Prasidh Krishna and Gurnoor Brar are the other quicks in the 15-member squad.

In the batting unit, Sai Sudharsan's inclusion also came with a caveat that his fitness will have to be cleared by the BCCI's Centre of Excellence (CoE). On India-A's recent tour of Sri Lanka, comprising two four-day games, the south-paw had starred with two hundreds.

The squad: Shubman Gill (Capt.), K.L. Rahul (Vice-captain), Yashasvi Jaiswal, Rishabh Pant (wk), Sai Sudharsan, Dhruv Jurel (wk), Ravindra Jadeja, Kuldeep Yadav, Manav Suthar, Jasprit Bumrah, Mohammed Siraj, Prasidh Krishna, Gurnoor Brar, Devdutt Padikkal, and Saransh Jain.

Note: Sai Sudharsan and Bumrah's selection subject to fitness.

INBRIEF



Gvardiol signs new five-year deal at Manchester City

Josko Gvardiol has signed a new five-year contract at Manchester City, the Premier League club announced on Tuesday. The Croatia international, whose previous deal had two years left to run, is now committed until 2031, with the option of an additional 12 months. The central defender made 122 appearances since arriving from RB Leipzig for £77 million in 2023.

Indian women go down to Malaysia in World jr. squash

Recently crowned World junior champion Anahat Singh won her contest but the Indian women’s team went down fighting 1-2 to Malaysia in a World Squash junior team championship contest in Ontario, Canada. Anahat brushed aside the challenge from Whitney Wilson 11-2, 11-4, 11-5 in the concluding match after India lost the first two. In the opening match, Rudra Singh lost to Harleen Tan 5-11, 4-11, 6-11 while Anika Dubey was involved in a five-game thriller with Ye San Lee before going down 8-11, 11-8, 11-8, 10-12, 9-11. The team will next take on South Africa, while the men will face off against Kuwait.

Punjab FC signs forward Gurkirat and Nishchal

Punjab FC has bolstered its squad ahead of the 2026-27 Indian Super League (ISL) season with the double signing of forward Gurkirat Singh and defender Nishchal Chandan. Both players have signed two-year agreements that will keep them with the Shers until May 31, 2028.

Laver Cup: Ruud completes Team Europe’s line-up

Europe’s line-up for the Laver Cup in London has been completed with Norway’s Casper Ruud named as the sixth member of the team to take on Team World. The World No. 13 will join Alexander Zverev, Carlos Alcaraz, Flavio Cobolli, Jakub Mensik and Rafael Jodar for the September 25-27 event. Team World, which will be captained by Andre Agassi, includes Alex de Minaur, Ben Shelton, Taylor Fritz, Learner Tien, Tommy Paul and Alexander Bublik.

Cucurella keeps De la Fuente tattoo pledge after WC win

Marc Cucurella revealed a new tattoo of coach Luis de la Fuente on his arm on Tuesday, keeping a promise he made before the country’s World Cup win. The left-back vowed at the start of the summer to get a tattoo of the coach’s face if Spain won the tournament. In the tattoo, De la Fuente is depicted wearing a suit and brandishing the World Cup.

LIVE TELECAST

▼
CWG 2026: Day 6, Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 1 p.m.
Durand Cup: Sony Sports Ten 5 & LIV, 7 p.m.

TVS launches mini bikes to help grassroots two-wheeler racing

S. Dipak Ragav
CHENNAI

TVS Motor Company has launched the TVS Apache RR 200 Mini to help youngsters take the first step into motorsports.

TVS gave away 10 mini bikes to the Madras Motor Sports Club in an event at the Madras International Karting Arena (MIKA) on Monday.

The purpose-built TVS Apache RR 200 Mini will form the backbone of a structured rider development programme for aspiring racers aged 10-14 years, equipping them with professional racing skills under the guidance of experienced instructors and TVS Racing champions. They will also be provided with requisite safety gear.

For a long time, India has not had access to mini



The first step: TVS gave away 10 mini bikes to the Madras Motor Sports Club on Monday.
SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

bikes, which are crucial for riders’ development and are enjoyed by their peers in Europe and Southeast Asia. These bikes promise to fill that gap, offering aspirants a chance to train their skills at an earlier age.

Young riders will be

trained at the MIKA karting track, with the option of the short loop version of the Madras International Circuit also available.

“We are working to create a grassroots-level programme where the youngsters can be trained.

Now we want to build grassroots-level youngsters who can eventually become a part of Rookie Cup and the Factory Racing Team,” said Vimal Sumbly, Head – Premium Business, TVS Motor Company.

“We are creating these

Premier League to trial goalkeeper injury rule

Associated Press
LONDON

The new Premier League season is set to trial a crack-down on goalkeepers who appear to feign injury in order to disturb the flow of the game or give time for coaches to instruct players. The English Football Association on Monday said the move has been approved by global football’s rulemaking panel.

“English football has received approval from the International Football Association Board to introduce a new goalkeeper injury trial for the 2026-27 season as part of its ongoing commitment to maintaining the pace and flow of matches,” it said. The BBC said the first game to include the trial will be the English League Cup match between Tranmere and Rochdale on Saturday.

South United beats CISF Protectors

DURAND CUP

Sports Bureau
KOLKATA

South United FC climbed to the top of Group-A with a comfortable 2-0 win over CISF Protectors in the 135th Durand Cup at the Kishore Bharati Stadium on Tuesday.

After a barren first half, the Bengaluru-based side broke the deadlock in the 65th minute from a corner. A powerful header by Roman James struck the upright before reaching Rishik Shetty, who tapped

home the rebound. South United sealed the victory in the 84th minute when substitute Ashish Chetry guided B. Abhiram’s measured cross into the net. The win took South United to the top of the standings on goal difference ahead of Mohun Bagan Super Giant, with both teams on three points.

Goalless draw Meanwhile, the Group-D opener between Imphal rivals TRAU FC and NEROCA FC ended in a goalless draw at the Khuman Lampak Stadium. Both teams created sev-

eral scoring opportunities in a closely contested encounter but failed to convert their chances. TRAU was reduced to 10 men after Ugandan midfielder Adriko Rogers was sent off for receiving his second yellow card. However, NEROCA failed to capitalise on the numerical advantage, and the match ended in a hard-fought 0-0 stalemate.

The results:
Group- A (Kolkata): South United FC 2 (Rishik Shetty 65, Ashish Chetry 84) bt CISF Protectors 0.
Group- D (Imphal): NEROCA FC 0 drew with TRAU FC 0.

CHESS

P.K. Ajith Kumar

Geneva will host the World chess championship match between D. Gukesh and Javokhir Sindarov from November 25 to December 15. Chennai-based Gukesh had won the title by beating China’s Ding Liren in Singapore two years ago while his Uzbek rival earned the right to be the challenger after winning the Candidates tournament.

Both players are aged 20, making it the youngest World title match in history.

Viswanathan Anand, world chess governing body FIDE’s interim president, said several countries, including India, the United States, and Cyprus, had expressed interest to host the event.

“FIDE has decided to stage the match on neutral soil and bring it to Geneva,



It’s a date! Sindarov will contest Gukesh for the world crown from November 25 to December 15.
FILE PHOTO

a city with a historic tradition of bringing nations and cultures together,” said the five-time World champion.

“We look forward to welcoming the global chess community to Switzerland. The local chess fans will have the opportunity to experience world-class chess in per-

son, while fans around the globe can follow online as the duel for the highest title in chess unfolds.”

President of the Swiss Chess Federation Andre Voegtlin said it was a truly special day for Swiss chess.

“Twenty-two years after Brissago (2004 World title match), an event of major global chess significance is

returning to Switzerland. It’s a moment that fills us with joy and motivation.”

Though Gukesh has had to go through some tough times after becoming the youngest ever World champion, in sharp contrast to the rapid rise of Sindarov, it should be a fascinating match between the two young men.

City’s Rodri sidelined for ‘short period’

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

Spain’s World Cup-winning captain Rodri will be sidelined for a short period following a minor back surgery, Manchester City said on Tuesday. “Manchester City can confirm Rodri has undergone successful minor back surgery,” the Premier League club said.

“He has undergone a procedure to address the issue and will begin a short period of rehabilitation.”

Zidane era begins for Les Bleus

FOOTBALL

Agence France-Presse
PARIS

Zinedine Zidane was appointed France coach on Tuesday, as widely expected, following the departure of Didier Deschamps, the French Football Federation announced.

Zidane, 54, had long been viewed as the leading candidate for the role and had been waiting for an opportunity to take charge of the national team for several years.

Deschamps’ tenure, which began in 2012, ended earlier this month after France finished fourth at the World Cup. He guided France to 2018 World Cup glory and the final four years later.

Zidane, Deschamps’



Zidane. REUTERS

teammate in the 1998 World Cup triumph, has been readying himself for the role since leaving Real Madrid in 2021.

“The France job was the only one I wanted,” Zidane said after his unveiling at the FFF headquarters in Paris. “I’ve had offers over these four or five years to take charge of a club and I turned them all down for the French national team”.

Mancini returns as Italy coach

Reuters
ROME

Former Italy manager Roberto Mancini will return for a second spell as national team coach, Italian Football Federation (FIGC) president Giovanni Malago said on Tuesday, while Claudio Ranieri will take over as technical director. Mancini will replace Gennaro Gattuso.

Malago announced the appointment during a Federal Council meeting.

“Mancini is the coach,” he said before confirming the decision at a press conference.

“I believed that the best person to become head coach was Roberto Mancini.”

The 61-year-old Mancini guided Italy to the European Championship title in 2021. He led Italy in 58 matches during his first spell and at club level has



Mancini. REUTERS

managed Inter Milan, Fiorentina and Manchester City, where he spent three years and guided it to its first Premier League title in 2011-12.

Former FIGC technical director Paolo Maldini and adviser Leonardo resigned from their roles on Monday after their primary candidate for the Italy coach’s position, Andrea Pirlo, had his appointment blocked due to his ties to a Russian betting firm.

Djokovic-Sabalenka duo tops US Open pairings

TENNIS

Agence France-Presse
PARIS

Serbian tennis legend Novak Djokovic and women’s No. 1 Aryna Sabalenka top the list of pairings entered for the US Open mixed doubles.

Both men’s World No.1 Jannik Sinner and second-ranked Carlos Alcaraz have not entered the competition which was heavily revamped last year.



Huge draw: Djokovic and Sabalenka will be watched with interest.

Reforms featured a shorter scoring format in the earlier rounds and a new scheduling slot – played over

er two days – before the singles draws in an attempt to encourage the top players to enter.

Djokovic, 39, and the 28-year-old Sabalenka are certain to feature among the initial six pairings selected according to the world rankings when the deadline for entries closes on August 17.

“Anytime you can bring women and men together on the same team, you showcase tennis at its best,” said USTA CEO Craig Tiley.

Sinner, who did not enter last year’s mixed doubles, is “prioritising” his health ahead of the tournament.

From a delivery boy to a KCL star.. the stellar rise of Krishna Devan

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Along the winding road leading to the KCA cricket stadium in Mangalapuram, his face stares at you from the numerous flex boards.

After all, the 27-year-old Krishna Devan is the toast of his hometown after he became the second most expensive player (₹11.20 lakh) in the KCL auction.

He was a self-taught javelin thrower and Kerala University champion before a shoulder injury brought a premature end to his athletics career. “I tried my luck with cricket after completing my BSc in Mathematics. I used to play tennis ball cricket,” he explained.

The youngster was forced to take on menial



Krishna Devan.

jobs to pursue his passion because of his family’s financial situation. However, after breaking two bats and losing a significant amount of money in stock trading, Krishna Devan found himself at a crossroads.

In a desperate midnight impulse, he packed his bags, rode his bike to Bengaluru and spent the next eight months working as a food delivery executive.

Yet, he couldn’t stay away from the sport for long. He played in tournaments during his spare time. Sagar, a club patron who got to know of Krishna Devan’s struggles, gifted him a full kit and five bats, urging him to return home and play.

Krishna Devan rejoined Kids Cricket Club and rapidly earned a reputation as a terrifying power-hitter. Calicut Globstars snapped him up for a modest ₹75,000 in the second season. His breathtaking unbeaten 11-ball 49 against Aries Kollam Sailors underlined his immense potential. A superb show in the NSK Trophy T20 event in June after being sidelined due to a thumb injury only helped his cause further.



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Abdusattorov upbeat about the Olympiad at home

The former World rapid champion admits being under pressure for the showpiece but believes the Uzbekistan squad is capable of going the distance; the 21-year-old says he will help Sindarov prepare for the World championship match against Gukesh in Geneva from November 25 to December 15

B. VELANKANNI RAJ

C. Shyam Sundar

The “children” of Vishy Anand are on the loose! These were the words of Russian chess legend Garry Kasparov after Indian GM D. Gukesh had won the Candidates in circa 2024 before going on to capture the World title (later that year).

He was referring to the growing legion of Indian chess players, especially those under the tutelage of Anand, who were taking the sport by storm.

The year (2024) was a golden one for India as it topped the Open and women’s categories in the Budapest Olympiad before Gukesh dethroned Ding Liren in the championship match.

As the Indians were raising the bar, Uzbekistan was making

its presence felt with its players coming to the fore with impactful performances of their own.

Nodirbek Abdusattorov had probably struck the first blow for the Uzbeks, winning the World Rapid title in 2021 at the age of 17, becoming the youngest-ever to do so.

A year later in 2022, he was at the forefront as Uzbekistan emerged the surprise winner in the Open event in the Olympiad in Mamallapuram (near Chennai).

Abdusattorov and Javokhir Sindarov, who has emerged as a name to reckon within the last one year, will be spearheading Uzbekistan’s charge to regain the gold in the upcoming Olympiad at home (in Samarkand).

The former World rapid champion, who was in Chennai recently for the Grand Masters tournament in the city, is confident of the team doing well in the Olympiad.

Gearing up

He said the squad had already held several training camps in Uzbekistan. The team is likely to comprise the Candidates winner Sindarov, Nodirbek Yakubboev and Shamsiddin Vokhidov besides Abdusattorov, with Mukhiddin Madaminov as the reserve.

This line-up, he said, could mount a serious challenge for the top prize.

“Our nation, our people will cheer for us. We understand that there will be a lot of pressure, and the expectations are very high,” he said in an interaction. “But I think we are ready for this challenge. We have gained a lot of experience by playing under tension.”

Abdusattorov said he would be helping out Sindarov as he prepares for the World championship match against Gukesh in Geneva (November 25 to December 15).

“I had joined his training camp for a week before the Candidates. For the upcoming World championship match, for sure, I will be part of his team. I will be training with him. From my perspective, he’s my friend, he’s close to me, and I will do my best to help him.”

Sindarov, during an interaction with Indian journalists at Norway Chess, had said that he didn’t even consider himself to be the best player in Uzbekistan and made known his admiration for Abdusattorov, who was was a sort of a hero for the other players.

He also believes the camaraderie among the Uzbek players will help in the pursuit of an Olympiad gold at home.

“In Uzbekistan, we are all good friends. We try to take it in a good spirit. We don’t see each other as competition or rivalry or enemies. We don’t have any such ideas. Especially after becoming Olympiad champions in 2022, that

friendship became stronger,” he further said. As a result, he said Uzbekistan had an advantage over other teams.

With the country’s players performing well consistently over the years, Abdusattorov said, “We have grown up together when we were young and this generation is the golden generation for Uzbek chess.”

That friendship is evident when Abdusattorov speaks glowingly about Sindarov. He said they have known each other since they were very young and competed in various age-group events.

“We played a lot against each other from our young age and it’s good when you have a competition within your country because you get inspired, you learn from them, we try to train together and it helps us to improve and to show better results. Ultimately I think this is the main reason why we are having so many good results,” he said.

Throwing his weight behind his friend and compatriot Sindarov, he said, “If Javokhir becomes the World champion, I think it’s going to be an exceptional year for Uzbekistan.”

Slight advantage for Gukesh

Turning his attention to the upcoming World Championship match between Sindarov and Gukesh, Abdusattorov said the Indian GM’s experience (of having played the last title match) would give him a slight advantage.

“Gukesh’s experience of playing the last World championship match gives him a little advantage. I think a lot depends on what kind of form and shape they will be in closer to the match. Also depends on preparation and some other aspects. But, it will be a lot of fun, a lot of entertainment for the chess world,” he added.

Abdusattorov has enormous respect for former World champion Vladimir Kramnik, who was the captain of the Uzbekistan team during the last World Cup, saying he and the other players learnt a lot from him.

“Kramnik is a big figure in the chess world... he helped us individually with our openings. We learned a lot from him. He recommended some openings which fit my style.”

About Anand’s remark regarding the possibility of two Indians playing the World Championship match in the future, he said with a grin, “... In the long run, of course. Two Uzbeks, two Indians, two Americans. At some point, it’s all possible.”

Also, he is happy with the new Candidates’ qualification criteria and the new format for the World Cup.

“Now, they are trying to get more spots... it’s 224, so they are trying to get more spots and they are trying to reduce



the number of days. I think it’s a good decision.”

The 21-year-old Uzbek is in awe of the rise of Indian chess and said players like M. Pranesh, who scored over Gukesh in the Chennai Grand Masters, were incredibly strong.

“I think they (the Indian youngsters) are a bit underestimated and underrated. If they have a 2,650 rating, I see them as 2,700 already,” said Abdusattorov.

He said Pranesh is a very good player and added that “He has huge potential and is also a very good Blitz player.”

Candidates back in focus

Abdusattorov is planning to have a shot at the World title and aims to qualify for the next Candidates in this cycle.

“I’m looking forward to qualifying for the Candidates. But first of all, I want to enjoy the game and really get joy from it,” said Abdusattorov, who failed to qualify for the Candidates tournament in 2026.

The young Uzbek chess star was also happy to return to Chennai, a happy hunting ground for him and even thought of going to the hotel where he had stayed during the 2022 Olympiad.

“I even checked how far away the hotel is where I stayed four years ago. I had an idea that maybe I can go to the hotel to relive some good memories...”

He has come a long way since those heady days in the southern city four years ago. Abdusattorov is now among the elite in chess as the ‘golden generation’ of Uzbekistan is primed and ‘on the loose’ to unleash its power on the global stage.

THE GIST

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